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GARNER
Madly Original

LOUIS VUITTON

LOUIS VUITTON

“I just want to keep taking risks. I think that’s what going to resonate with people. *That I gave everything*, you know? You’ve got to go all in.”

—

Julia Garner

Dress, SCHIAPARELLI COUTURE.

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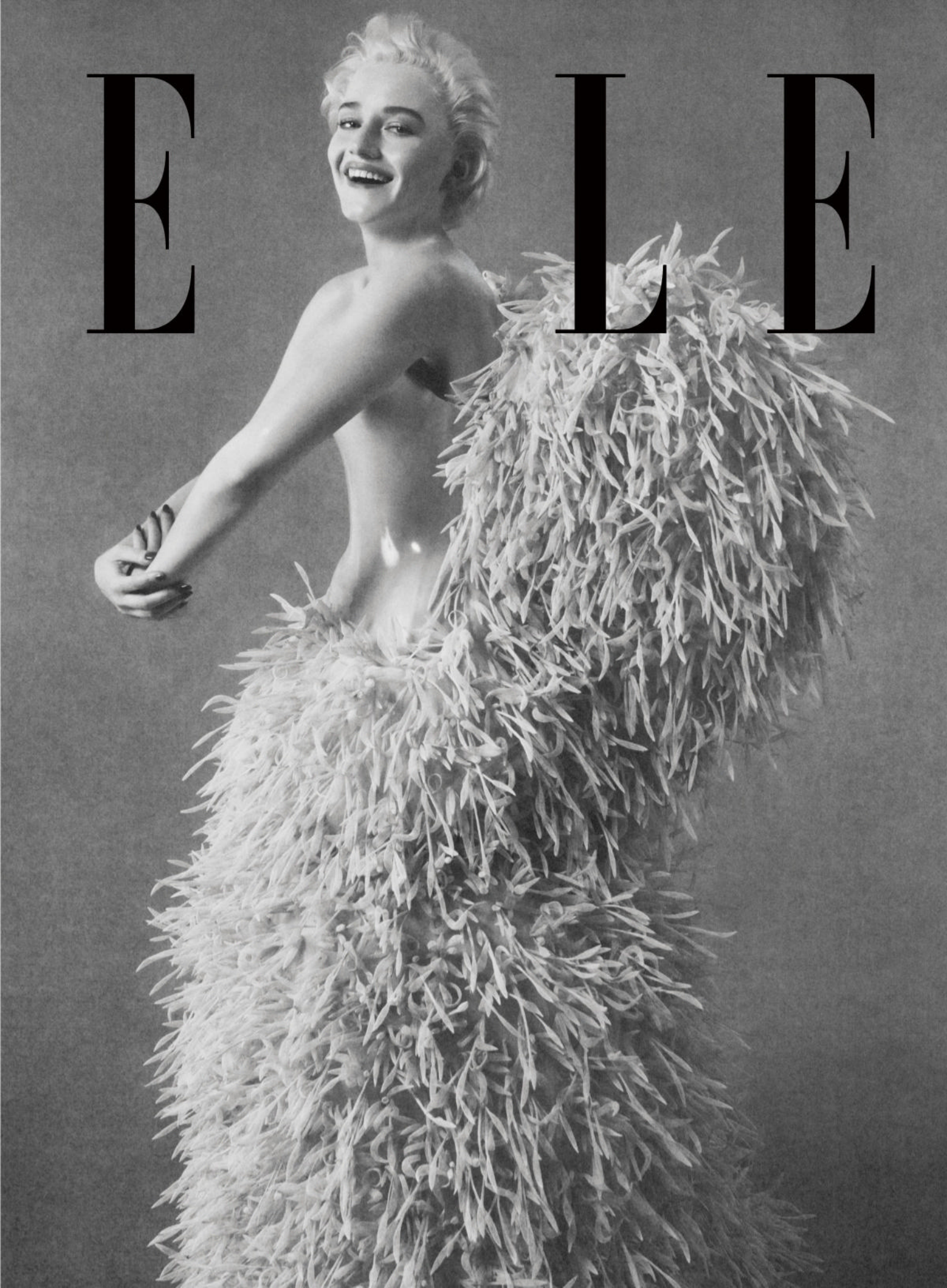

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STEVEN KLEIN

Julia Garner might be the ultimate Hollywood chameleon, disappearing into characters as varied as scammer Anna Delvey in *Inventing Anna* and nerdy crypto founder Caroline Ellison in *The Altruists*. Graham Moore, the creator of the latter series, tells writer Logan Hill that like a high diver, Garner "will choose to jump from the highest board into the deepest water." In our cover story, she channels a heroine of a different era, complete with a cigarette—a vestige of that epoch I obviously have mixed emotions about. Still, it can't be denied that from our screens (*The Shards*; *Love Story: John F. Kennedy Jr. & Carolyn Bessette*) to the fashion imagery flooding our feeds—which is drawing on the past more than ever—smoking is being glamorized. For better or worse, it is back in the cultural conversation. (Note: Garner tells us that she isn't a smoker—and it's not a habit I endorse, either.) *Go to ELLE's social channels to see the actress field our questions in our Ask Me Anything series.*

Sombr has been unmissable in 2026, from his chart-topping hits and viral music videos to being selected by Taylor Swift to perform two of her hits at her Songwriters Hall of Fame induction ceremony. On page 86, the rock star tells Content Strategy Manager, Video and Social, Samuel Maude about navigating fame, body image, and controversy. *For more with Sombr, go to ELLE's social channels to see him curate a personal playlist for our Sounding Board franchise.*

For fantastical fall fashion, look no further than Nicolas Ghesquière, whose Louis Vuitton cruise collection shines against the backdrop of a Brutalist building on page 98. Plus, 20 years in business is no small feat, especially for an independent designer. Erdem Moralioglu is celebrating two decades of bringing historical muses to life—for more, see page 41. Also in our Front Row section: Colombian designer Manuela Álvarez is making global waves with her brand MAZ, and this season's *Project Runway* winner, 23-year-old Jude Mikulencak, impressed the judging panel with his beyond-his-years talent.

In our beauty pages, we report on why Mexico City is the next big beauty destination, from the best homegrown brands to the botanical-inspired perfumes that collectors are clamoring for. We also profile artist Martine Gutierrez, who has created a fashion magazine with herself as the star model.

To mark Breast Cancer Awareness Month, we report on a new technology that may offer the ability to detect recurrences of breast cancer earlier via a simple blood test. *For more coverage of breast cancer advances, go to ELLE.com.*

In honor of National Hispanic Heritage Month, our Perspectives section includes profiles of several inspiring Latina creatives. *To read about more inspiring women, including the female broadcasters behind the FIFA World Cup, visit ELLE.com.* The duo behind BASA Atelier is rethinking architecture with a multidisciplinary approach, which cofounder Ana Amelia Batlle Cabral describes as "*Sí a todo*." Contramar chef Gabriela Cámara is bringing one of Mexico City's most famous restaurants stateside with a Las Vegas outpost. And though she published *The House of the Spirits* back in 1982, Isabel Allende's narrative power is such that the story lives on, most recently in a Prime Video series this past spring. With her latest book, *Story Telling*, out now, Allende speaks with the show's executive producer, Eva Longoria, on page 70. As the legendary novelist says, "Stories define us."

NINA GARCIA, EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

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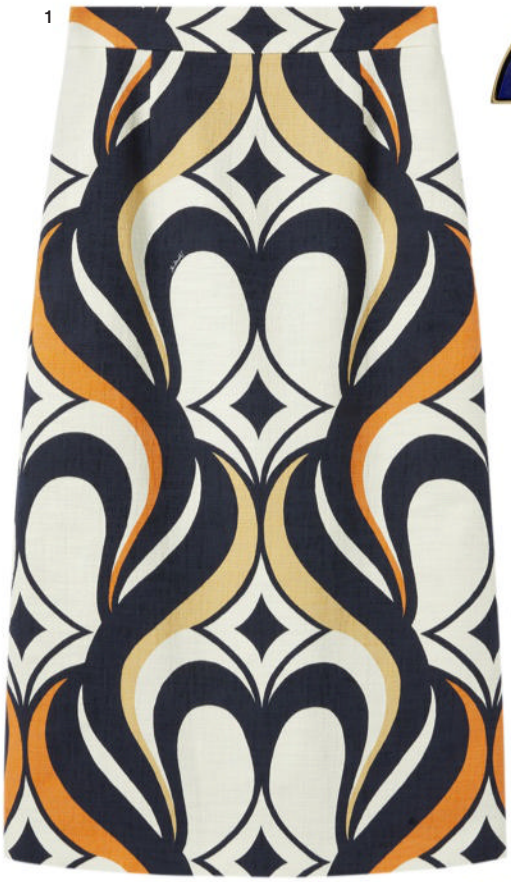
Nina's Edit

CIAO BELLA

From morning espresso to evening aperitivo, ELLE Editor-in-Chief Nina Garcia navigates Milan with a Tumi suitcase full of sophisticated staples and local finds.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1. Skirt, LA DOUBLEJ, ladoublej.com.

2. Earrings, MAHNAZ COLLECTION, modaoperandi.com.

3. Luggage, TUMI, tumi.com.

4. Vase, GINORI 1735, ginori1735.com.

5. Pumps, AQUAZZURA, aquazzura.com.

6. Plate, GINORI 1735, cabanamagazine.com.

7. Ring, GIORGIO B, giorgiob.com.

8. Sunglasses, BOTTEGA VENETA, bottegaveneta.com.

9. Flutes, NASON MORETTI, nasonmoretti.com.

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On Sombr: Jacket, Rabanne. Shirt, Junk Food Clothing. Pants, Gucci. For Sombr's grooming look, try Capture Le Sérum, Capture Soft Creme, and Hydrating Invisible UV Fluid Broad Spectrum SPF 50. All, Dior. *Photographed by Steven Klein; styled by Paul Sinclaire; hair by Ward at Bryant Artists; makeup by Dick Page at MA+ Group; manicure by Honey for P.Shine; produced by Travis Kiewel at ThatOneProduction.*

ANDY HARRINGTON

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The BAG

Alessandro Michele updates the DeVain bag, a Valentino Garavani staple, with a riot of beaded flowers channeling his fall collection's '80s exuberance.

Handbag, VALENTINO GARAVANI.

COURTESY OF THE DESIGNERS.

The NECKLACE

The time-honored charm necklace finds new life with Sauer's version, featuring painterly treasures and precious stones like lapis lazuli, jasper, and diamonds.

Necklace, SAUER.

The SHOE

Khaite gives the humble pump a seductive new attitude. Its Eve style boasts a sculptural silhouette defined by a curved heel and softly ruched surface.

Pumps, KHAITE.

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Past Perfect

From Bulgari's Eclettica High Jewelry collection to landmark anniversaries, this season celebrates heritage through a modern lens.

PHOTOGRAPHED BY ADRIEN DUBOST
STYLED BY STILEMA STUDIO

High Jewelry necklace, BULGARI.

→MAP QUEST

The best clothes evoke a sense of place. Just ask Sander Lak, whose eponymous line draws inspiration from the cities he's lived in and loved. For fall 2026, Lak, who also founded the now-defunct cult label Sies Marjan, looked to Los Angeles after dark. With fuchsia suits, tangerine cable-knit sweaters, and burgundy pants, the collection is proof that a city's mood—and palette—can be worn. *sanderlak.com.*

↓PARALLEL LIVES

For the first time, the careers of painters and spouses Lee Krasner and Jackson Pollock come together in *Krasner and Pollock: Past Continuous* at the Metropolitan Museum of Art. Spanning over 120 works, the exhibition traces two distinct yet intertwined artistic visions, casting both legacies in a fresh light. *October 4 to January 31, 2027, metmuseum.org.*

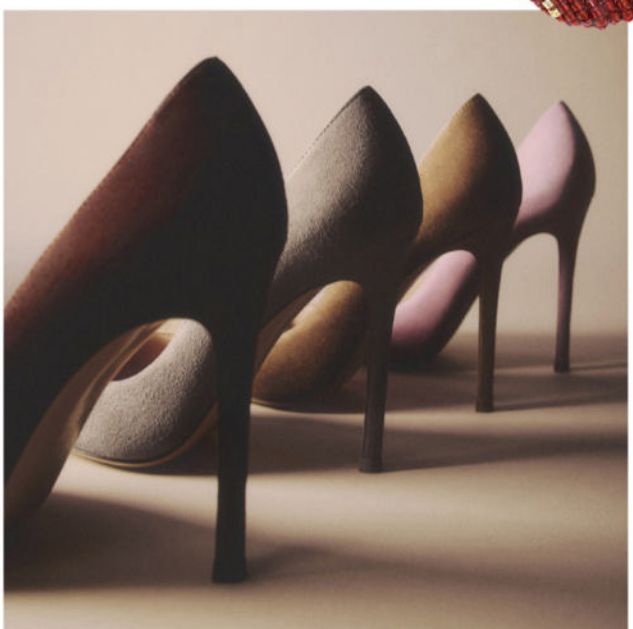
Bald Eagle (1955) by Lee Krasner.

→WALK DOWN MEMORY LANE

Twenty years, countless red carpets, and more than a few very famous feet later, Gianvito Rossi is celebrating in style. A new Rizzoli book, *Gianvito Rossi: My Shoes,* created by Rossi with a preface by Carine Roitfeld, marks the Italian brand's milestone anniversary, revisiting the silhouettes that define its approach to footwear. And because just one birthday tribute wasn't enough, the label toasted its 20th with a starry gathering at Milan Fashion Week. *rizzoliusa.com.*

→ALL THAT GLITTERS

A generations-deep tradition of goldsmithing informs Susana Vega's jewelry, where family craftsmanship meets a modern, architectural perspective. The Venezuelan designer, now based in Houston, Texas, draws on geometric sequences and her Latin heritage to inform her handmade glass bead, gold, and wood creations. *susanavegajewelry.com.*



BALD EAGLE (1955) BY LEE KRASNER: COURTESY OF POLLOCK-KRASNER FOUNDATION AND ARTIST RIGHTS SOCIETY; REMAINING IMAGES: COURTESY OF THE DESIGNERS.

Trending

The Promenade (1870) by Pierre-Auguste Renoir.

↑FRENCH CONNECTION
Pierre-Auguste Renoir knew the magic of a party wasn't the event itself, but everything around it. At the National Gallery in London, *Renoir and Love* captures that chemistry, from hazy gardens to whirling Parisian dance floors that embody the Impressionist's joie de vivre. *October 3 to January 31, 2027, nationalgallery.org.uk.*

←SHAPE OF THINGS
Scandi style isn't exclusive to the region's wardrobes. The Copenhagen-based interior brand Louise Roe brings that same understated sensibility home with sculptural vases and artful objects. Imbued in the minimal Danish designs are if-you-know-you-know references to the Bauhaus and Brutalist movements. *louise-roe.com.*

→CONSIDERED CRAFT
At Cordera, relaxed dressing meets an artisanal point of view. Founded by sisters Mónica and María Cordera in Galicia, the Spanish label centers on casual proportions and thoughtful materials. Its slouchy tailoring and tactile knits telegraph ease, an approach that extends to its artisan-beaded bags. Handcrafted in Guatemala in collaboration with local female makers, the colorful keepalls add personality to the brand's pared-back universe. *cordera.es.*

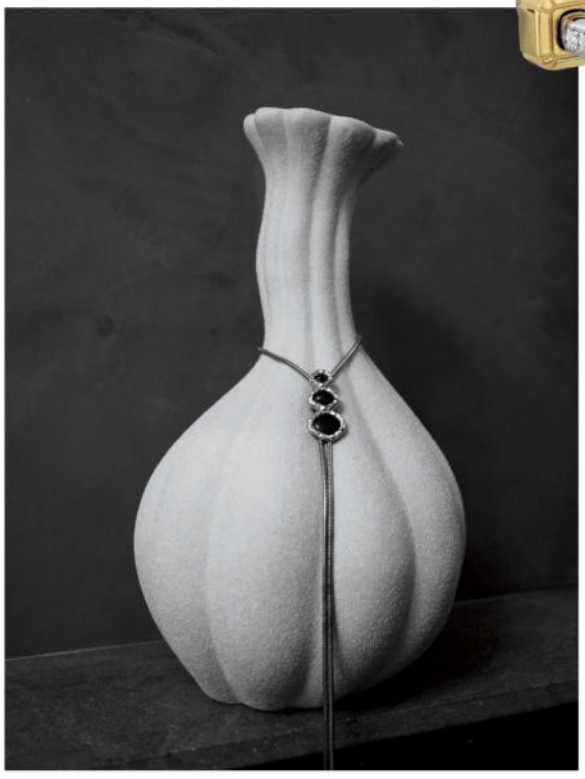
←ZOOM OUT
At Christie's New York, Boucheron honors founder Frédéric Boucheron in an exhibit tracing the maison from 1858 to today. Told in four chapters—couture, nature, architecture, and innovation— the show culminates in the brand's latest Carte Blanche High Jewelry collection (High Jewelry ring, left). *October 9 to 18, boucheron.com.*

THE PROMENADE (1870) BY PIERRE-AUGUSTE RENOIR, COURTESY OF THE J. PAUL GETTY MUSEUM; CARTIER FOUNDATION; COURTESY OF ERNEST SACKVILLE; *UNTITLED*, FROM THE SERIES *LOS ALAMOS* (1974) BY WILLIAM EGGLESTON; COURTESY OF THE EGGLESTON ARTISTIC TRUST; DAVID ZWIRNER; AND THE WILSON CENTRE FOR PHOTOGRAPHY; REMAINING IMAGES: COURTESY OF THE DESIGNERS.

→GATHERING GROUND
Ibrahim Mahama is turning Fondation Cartier into a meeting place for the past, present, and future. In *The Harvest Season*, the Ghanaian artist revisits his monumental installations alongside site-specific new work. But this isn't a solo affair: Mahama invited nine artists and collectives, including photographer James Barnor and textile artist and photographer Zohra Opoku, to exhibit their creations as well as his own. *October 22 to February 28, 2027, fondationcartier.com*.

Parliament of Ghosts (2005) by Ibrahim Mahama.

↑PRECIOUS HARDWARE
The world might know Eéra as the name behind Dua Lipa's nontraditional engagement ring, but the Milanese jewelry brand has plenty more up its sleeve. Founded by Chiara Capitani and Romy Blanga, Eéra trades traditional fine jewelry codes for something altogether more industrial and unexpected. Its unlikely starting point? A snap hook the pair stumbled across in a Tokyo vintage store, which inspired their now-signature hardware and industrial forms. *eera.com*.



↓TRUE COLORS
William Eggleston made the everyday impossible to ignore. Fifty years after *William Eggleston's Guide* shook up the photography world, The Photographers' Gallery in London revisits the work that made saturated color a serious artistic proposition and transformed motel rooms, parked cars, and corners of the American South into high art. *October 14 to February 21, 2027, thephotographersgallery.org.uk*.

↑TIE ONE ON
The bolo tie has left the ranch and is heading downtown. New York–based brand Bolola gives the Western classic a polished rethink, turning it into sculptural jewelry more fit for SoHo than the saloon. A clever sliding mechanism means each piece can be worn high and traditional or dropped low as a statement necklace, while gold and rhodium plating, gemstones, and lab-grown diamonds add shine. *bololanyc.com*.

Untitled, from the series *Los Alamos* (circa 1974) by William Eggleston.

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Erdem fall 2024.

PHOTOGRAPHED BY RUBY PLUHAR.

Back to the Future

Twenty years ago, *Erdem Moralioglu debuted his namesake label.* The vision remains what it was then—quintessentially him. *By Adrienne Gaffney*

Moralioglu at his desk in 2024.

In 2005, Erdem Moralioglu came on the scene, already a talented designer who melded ladylike elegance with an intelligent voice. Over the course of two decades, many fashion brands either shutter or are bought by larger companies. What the still-independent Moralioglu has achieved is something special: maintaining Erdem as he wants it to be.

His George Sand–inspired runway debut in 2006 landed with a splash. Filled with wool coats, avian-patterned dresses, embroidery, and lace, the pieces felt refined in a classically British way, while remaining sophisticated and modern. In the intervening years, he's dressed Michelle Obama, Kate Middleton, and Nicole Kidman, and designed costumes for the Royal Ballet, in collaboration with choreographer Christopher Wheeldon. In 2020, he was awarded an MBE. His pieces have been shown at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the Victoria & Albert Museum, and the Louvre. "Twenty years feels both extraordinary and slightly surreal. When I showed my first collection, I certainly wasn't thinking about anniversaries," says Moralioglu, who is now a very youthful 48. But what the moment presents is an opportunity for him to take a wide-angle view of what he has built. "What matters most to me isn't the milestone itself, but the fact that the work has been able to keep evolving. I've always seen each collection as another chapter, rather than a stand-alone moment. Looking back, I realize that certain ideas have quietly resurfaced over the years, transformed by time and different perspectives."

His design process has changed very little as the brand has grown. "I still begin every collection with research, storytelling, and a woman whose life opens the door to a much larger world. That curiosity remains exactly as it was 20 years ago," Moralioglu says. After growing up in Canada, he studied at London's Royal College of Art and now lives in London with his husband. Throughout his career, he's drawn inspiration from women like Deborah Cavendish, the Duchess of Devonshire—one of the famed Mitford sisters—as well as the English poet and author Radclyffe Hall, the contemporary painter Kaye Donachie, and the soprano Maria Callas. For his spring 2024 collection, the duchess was his muse, and the exhibit *Erdem: Imaginary Conversations* at Chatsworth House paired pieces from her archive with his own designs to illustrate how her style shaped the collection. The show included runway gowns made from remnants of the house's curtains, embroidered by Cecily Lasnet, the duchess's great-granddaughter and Stella Tennant's daughter. "I've always been fascinated by remarkable women whose lives resist simple categorization," he says. "Writers, performers, artists, explorers, collectors—they're people who created their own worlds rather than fitting comfortably into someone else's."

Erdem's fall 2026 collection let Moralioglu take a thoughtful look back at two decades of these inspirations. "The

MORALIOGLU: RUBY PLUHAR; VAN SEENUS: PAUL KOOIKER; MOODBOARD: EMMA HARRIES; FALL 2026 MODELS: COURTESY OF THE DESIGNER.

Model Guinevere van Seenus wears a look from spring 2020.

"I've always been fascinated *by remarkable women* whose lives *resist simple categorization.*"

The designer's moodboard for his fall 2024 collection.

starting point was an impossible idea: What if all the extraordinary women who have inspired my work over the last 20 years could meet one another? Not as historical figures, but as contemporaries, sharing the same room, exchanging ideas and influencing each other," he says. The collection, titled "The Imaginary Conversation," was romantic and classically feminine, featuring embroidered dresses in textured satin, blazers lined in tulle, dark floral patterns, and wool pieces with embroidered flowers.

"The process felt very different from previous collections, because I wasn't researching a singular person. I was researching my own archive. Rather than reproducing earlier work, I wanted to take fragments from different moments and combine them into something unexpected," Moralioglu says. "Today I'm perhaps less interested in biography than in the emotional atmosphere surrounding a person. A single photograph, a room, a letter, a painting, or an object can sometimes reveal more than a chronology of events. I'm drawn to those fragments, because they leave space for imagination."

There's a timelessness to Erdem that might explain how, in a wildly changing fashion landscape, the brand has been able to maintain a genuine spirit. That's not to say that things haven't changed. They have—but on Moralioglu's terms.

"Experience has taught me to trust instinct more, to know what deserves attention and what can be left unsaid," the designer says. "As fashion has become increasingly fast and image-driven, I've found myself becoming even more committed to making clothes with longevity, emotional resonance, and exceptional craftsmanship. Those qualities feel more relevant to me now than ever."

Looks from fall 2026.

Global *Citizen*

Manuela Álvarez is making worldwide waves with her line MAZ.

By Mekita Rivas

Manuela Álvarez needs a moment. The founder and creative director of the slow fashion brand MAZ began the year with big news: She had been selected as a semifinalist for the LVMH Prize. (Established in 2013, the coveted award grants the winner a €400,000 endowment and expert mentorship.) She was fresh off releasing her Raíz de Fénix collection with Adidas, becoming the second Latin American brand to develop a full collection for the athleticwear giant. And that was before she took on the task of designing looks for Colombia's national soccer team for the 2026 FIFA World Cup, in collaboration with Adidas. "This year, everything has happened so fast," Álvarez tells ELLE. "It's definitely the Fire Horse year for us."

Though she didn't clinch the LVMH Prize, being recognized at that level was a long time in the making. Born in Bogotá, Colombia, Álvarez realized around age nine that she was the creative type. But when it came time to choose a course of study, "I was between fashion and culinary school," Álvarez recalls. "I did a lot of research, analyzing which one was the better path for me." Her investigative work led her to Istituto Marangoni in Milan, where she studied fashion design. "It was this competition of these talented people who already knew how to draw, how to sketch, how to sew. And I was like, 'Oh my God, I'm really behind.' "

Ultimately, she heeded the advice of a favorite instructor, who encouraged her to take a closer look at her cultural roots for creative inspiration. Upon some reflection, the budding designer concluded that she had to do away with the stereotypes about what constitutes Latin American style.

"I was brought up to think that the only fashion that could be acknowledged in Latin America or Colombia was the tropical-chic, Caribbean aesthetic, but I'm from the middle of the mountains in Bogotá," Álvarez says. "When I realized that, I got to know myself as a creative in a different kind of vibe." According

> "I was brought up to think that the only fashion that could be acknowledged in Latin America...was the tropical-chic, Caribbean aesthetic."

to Álvarez, about 90 percent of the label's products are handmade by women from traditional and ancestral Indigenous and artisan communities throughout Colombia, and nearly 90 percent of its fabrics are handmade in-house.

Looking ahead, Álvarez sees a future *sin límites*. "Everything just clicked in my head and in my soul when we began to work with the communities," she says. "Yes, we can be sophisticated, cosmopolitan, chic, global, cool, contemporary—but with the foundation that everything is handmade. Everything is high-end artisanship. That's the whole vibe."

A look from MAZ's Alma Feral collection for fall 2026.

Looks from the 2025 MAZ collaboration with Adidas.

COURTESY OF THE DESIGNER.

JENNIFER LAWRENCE

Elegance is an attitude

LONGINES

THE LONGINES
MASTER COLLECTION

An image from La Mama's debut collection.

The Carry Diaries

Two fashion-industry veterans team up for a new brand that marries luxury and real life. *By Véronique Hyland*

Kate Aubrey had just treated herself to a luxury handbag. She was on set for a fashion shoot, "and within two seconds, someone's pen gets on the bottom of it," she gripes. Two weeks later, she spilled chocolate on it while on a train. "The bag was destroyed. I had worn it twice, and it was probably $4,000—or $2,000 per wear."

For Aubrey and her business partner, Kyra Griffin, the moment brought home the fact that high fashion—the industry they have spent their careers in—wasn't serving their lives as busy working moms. But products marketed to mothers had a cutesy sensibility that didn't fit the hard-edged aesthetic the two have cultivated with their creative agency, KStudio, where they've worked with brands like Tom Ford and talent like Steven Klein. "Most brands touching on motherhood—they're soft, they're bohemian," Griffin points out.

Not so for La Mama, their new bag line. They're launching with the LM1, a large carryall in stamped vegan leather in black and white—along with pouches in five different sizes. The style allows you to carry your life around with you without looking overburdened. It can, as Aubrey and Griffin do, go seamlessly from school drop-off to a fashion shoot (not to mention stand up to spills). Aubrey calls the process of creating La Mama "very autobiographical. We were living these crazy, fabulous lives, but dealing with chaos."

Today, Aubrey and Griffin are camped out at a modernist home that will serve as the backdrop for a campaign shoot. They not only finish each other's sentences but speak with the fluency of those who've spent their lives translating abstract ideas into high-gloss visuals. "It's really about that tension between chaos and control, disorder and polish," Griffin says. Aubrey adds that La Mama "is like Larry David meets Carine Roitfeld. She may be in an incredible Prada trench, but what's happening to her in that moment is funny, or very relatable."

They are bringing their slick aesthetic—and mordant sense of humor—to campaigns that are in step with our growing cultural transparency around motherhood, whether it's Sarah Hoover's memoir *The Motherload* or *Margo's Got Money Troubles*. One spot features a sharply dressed yet frazzled woman in a freight elevator, while voicemails inspired by real ones from Aubrey's and Griffin's inboxes play on the soundtrack. But they don't see their audience as solely moms—or solely women. A number of men, including actors and stylish NBA players, have already requested the bags. Could a @leaguefits cameo be next?

> "It's really about that tension between chaos and control, disorder and polish."
>
> —KYRA GRIFFIN

PHOTOGRAPHED BY LEWIS MIRRETT.

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VIP *Treatment*

A new app aims to index your wardrobe—and elevate the luxury experience. *By Dale Arden Chong*

As I stood staring at my overflowing closet, the idea of creating a digital database for every piece in my wardrobe felt insurmountable. Luckily, a team member from the new app Vêtir was en route to do it for me. My day was business as usual as she photographed piece after piece—my studded Khaite bag, a vintage Givenchy top, platform Gucci loafers, and a quirky Simon Miller dress—until, a few hours later, she was finished.

Once my wardrobe was officially in the system, the real fun began. I used the AI Stylist chat to scan my closet and identify any gaps in my wardrobe. The findings? My strengths lie in premium denim, leather, and knitwear, but my closet was missing additional basics like crisp button-downs, trousers, and a sculptural bag. To fill those gaps, it provided several designer options for purchase.

Though plenty of AI-powered closet management apps exist today, Vêtir (French for "to dress") stands out for its focus on the personal shopping experience, making anyone feel like a Very Important Client—otherwise known as a VIC. Founded by industry vet Kate Davidson Hudson, who's held positions at ELLE and LuisaViaRoma and cofounded Editorialist, Vêtir employs AI to bring bespoke shopping—which usually includes private appointments, custom curation, and dedicated stylists—together onto a single platform. The company recently raised $5.5 million in a Series A funding round and was valued at $150 million. "What makes Vêtir truly different is that we're not simply a digital closet app—we're a digital closet within a much larger, personalized wardrobe operating system," Davidson Hudson tells ELLE. "We weren't founded by technologists looking at fashion from the outside. We were built by people who have spent their careers in luxury fashion, editorial, and personal shopping, so we understand that luxury is deeply personal, emotional, and constantly evolving."

Clockwise from top left: a Chloé necklace and jacket, a Fendi bag, and Gucci boots.

Vêtir makes recommendations based on what you already own, aiming to provide each person with curated options from its many luxury brand partners, which include Bottega Veneta, Saint Laurent, Chloé, and Fendi. Through the platform, you can also connect with an AI-powered stylist, as I did, or work with one of Vêtir's professional stylists to create looks—which you can visualize on your avatar—pulled from your closet, as well as complementary pieces that can be shipped directly to your door. Because the app (as well as its stylists) has access to your entire wardrobe, it gets a big-picture view, enabling it to suggest new ways to style your favorite pieces—and the more it learns about your tastes and preferences, the more personalized its advice will become. For me, that resulted in considering tailored blazers and other menswear-inspired pieces to add structure to my wardrobe.

Finally, for those who love to shop the latest designer collections as they arrive, Vêtir has created its own version of a trunk show, presenting its clients with exclusive first looks and access to covetable items, with the option to purchase the pieces you're eyeing directly through the app. With a more holistic view into my wardrobe, along with the guidance of a personal stylist, I can now curate a shopping experience tailored precisely to me—all in the palm of my hand.

The author during New York Fashion Week.

CHONG: DENIS GUTIERREZ-OGRING; CHLOÉ NECKLACE AND JACKET: COURTESY OF MODA OPERANDI; REMAINING IMAGES: COURTESY OF THE DESIGNERS.

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Mikulencak at work.

All *Sewn Up*

Jude Mikulencak's mastery of tailoring led him to *Project Runway* victory.

By Samuel Maude

Jude Mikulencak didn't touch a sewing machine until he was 17. He had a creative brain, often painting and drawing as a child, but he didn't start leaning into textiles and tailoring until he moved from his hometown of New Orleans to Brooklyn. Now only 23, Mikulencak is the winner of Season 22 of *Project Runway*. "I'm deeply fascinated with the craft and the art of [fashion]," Mikulencak says. "I've pushed myself a lot in these years. Since the day that I put down my paintbrush and decided I was going to sew, I don't know if I've taken one day off."

While his dedicated interest in fashion may be new, Mikulencak remembers looking through his mom's closet as a teenager, fascinated with the construction of her clothes. She was also the one who made him watch *McQueen*, the documentary on the celebrated designer. The life of the icon only made him lean further into the world of structure.

After experimenting with the sewing machine but having no luck finding a tailoring apprenticeship in New Orleans, he came to New York at 18, where he quickly found a mentor in Craig Robinson. The legendary Brooklyn tailor took Mikulencak under his wing. At the same time, Mikulencak enrolled at the Pratt Institute, studying fashion design. Then *Project Runway* called. "I was there for seven weeks, and I think I made 16 looks, which is the most I've produced in that amount of time, ever," he says. "I did a speed run of what two years would've been like. I learned about time management, making some sacrifices along the way and trying to put forth the best thing I could that represents me."

> "Since the day I decided I was going to sew, I don't know if I've taken one day off."

His understanding of tailoring and form stood out, specifically in the "Designing with the Stars" challenge, a crossover with *Dancing with the Stars*, where he designed a look for pro ballroom dancer Alan Bersten. "It was the only time that I did menswear, and I loved that one," Mikulencak says. "I had a lot of fun with the pants, with all this motion."

At first, Mikulencak was nervous about facing the judging panel, including host, judge, and executive producer Heidi Klum, model and entrepreneur Tyra Banks, image architect Law Roach, and ELLE Editor-in-Chief Nina Garcia. But he grew to see the critiques as a unique opportunity. "They are some of the coolest people that I've ever had looking at my work," Mikulencak says. "I'm so young, and I still have so much to learn."

Notes from Christian Siriano, the show's mentor, who won the competition at age 21 himself and often pushed him to take things one step further, were particularly meaningful. Mikulencak also remembers a game-changing criticism from Roach. "He said that I need to learn more about how I speak about my work and how I present myself."

Following his win and the $200,000 prize, the designer hopes to take his brand to the next level. His strategy is to create one-of-a-kind pieces for clients, following his brand's ethos: tailored, historical, and goth-adjacent. "I love finding the beauty in the mundane," Mikulencak says. "I've always appreciated a gray, rainy day. It has its own special romance, and I try to re-create that feeling in my clothes."

Two of Mikulencak's designs for *Project Runway*.

SPENCER PAZER/DISNEY

CHILL FACTOR

As temperatures dip, rethink *cold-weather classics* with sumptuous layers and a jolt of primary color. Moncler's Re-Icons project—a centerpiece of *its newly opened Fifth Avenue flagship* in New York—brings this modern approach to tried and true outerwear shapes.

Moncler Re-Icons fall 2026.

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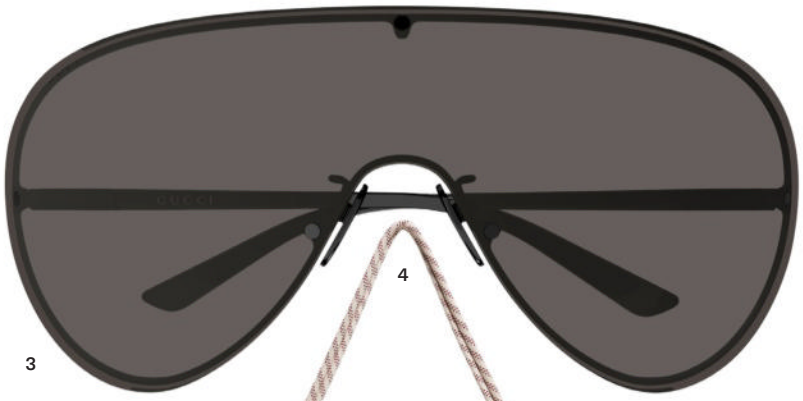

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1. Watch, ROLEX, rolex.com.

2. Boots, ISABEL MARANT, isabelmarant.com.

3. Sunglasses, GUCCI, gucci.com.

4. Bag, MONCLER RE-ICONS, moncler.com.

5. Scarf, CHARVET, mrporter.com.

6. Turtleneck, CELINE, celine.com.

7. Addict Lip Maximizer, DIOR, dior.com.

8. Ring, SPINELLI KILCOLLIN, spinellikilcollin.com.

9. Earrings, DAVID YURMAN, davidyurman.com.

10. Coat, CELINE, celine.com.

COURTESY OF THE DESIGNERS AND BRANDS.

Vienna's Mandarin Oriental.

TIMELESS CITY

Built on arts, crafts, and grand flourishes, Vienna is having its moment all over again.

By Todd Plummer

Any conversation about Vienna inevitably turns to the balls—more than 450 a year, beginning like clockwork on November 11 and carrying the city through the darkest days of winter until spring.

The Opera Ball is the most famous. Debutante couples, around 160 in all, dance to "The Blue Danube" waltz in a ceremony that hasn't changed much since the 1800s: long gowns for the ladies, tailcoats and white bow ties for the gentlemen, and a theater full of onlookers. The Vienna Philharmonic Ball is the more glamorous ticket, drawing musicians, diplomats, and old Viennese families. But the events don't stop there. There are balls for lawyers, coffee brewers, hunters, bakers, and scientists—nearly every social stratum of the city has one.

Glamorous, isn't it? There's something defiantly optimistic about an entire city collectively agreeing to put on its best finery and waltz until dawn, over and over, for months and years and now centuries on end. What began as a favored pastime of the 18th-century Habsburgs persists to the present day as a genuine focal point of civic life, rather than a costume drama staged for visitors. (Though outsiders are indeed welcome, with tickets available online to most anyone with the right dress and willingness to make the trip to Vienna in winter.)

According to the Vienna Tourist Board, the city saw a record number of visitors in 2025, and luxury investment has followed close behind. Yet unlike so many capitals racing to reinvent themselves, Vienna has resisted the temptation to prove its relevance with glass towers and modern architectural statements. Nearly all of the city's most exciting hotels are rooted in old buildings: The Rosewood Vienna debuted in 2022 in a 19th-century former bank headquarters, while the Mandarin Oriental, Vienna opened late last year inside a restored Art Nouveau courthouse. This past summer brought the long-anticipated relaunch of Palais Coburg, a five-star hotel set inside the former home of the Saxe-Coburgs, an aristocratic family with ties to the British royals. Next year will see the return of the romantic Hotel Bristol, a Belle Epoque landmark. Meanwhile, at the Hotel Sacher—a bastion of old-world luxury that turned 150 this year—the rooms are as opulent and the chocolate Sacher-Torte as decadent as ever.

Vienna's great luxury is continuity. Here, older buildings tend to be patiently restored, sometimes over decades, with an appreciation for authenticity; celebrated for their heritage rather than gutted for the next new thing. That same instinct makes Vienna one of the most rewarding shopping destinations in Europe. The Innere Stadt old town is a treasure trove of family-run ateliers and retailers. At J. & L. Lobmeyr, the firm whose Sputnik chandeliers famously illuminate the Metropolitan Opera House in New York, crystal is still cut and

Lobmeyr lights at the Golden Hall of the Musikverein, a concert venue. Right: Lobmeyr crystal pieces.

engraved by hand, as it has been since the company's founding in 1823. Carl Auböck, established in the early 1900s, continues to produce sculptural brass and leather objects using techniques passed down for generations. The tiny chocolate shop Altmann & Kühne, open since 1928, wraps its creations in elaborate foils and boxes that still capture the glamour of bygone times. None of it feels preserved for tourists—in the age of same-day delivery, these businesses never stopped believing there was value in doing things slowly, and in person.

There's something *defiantly optimistic* about an entire city collectively agreeing to put on its best finery and waltz until dawn.

Fashion designer Nina Hollein, who was born in Vienna and lives in New York, sees that continuity everywhere when she returns—her father lives in the apartment where she spent her childhood, unchanged in the last 55 years. She always visits her usual circuit of favorites: breakfast at Café Goldegg, exhibits at the Kunsthistorisches Museum, the 7th District for shopping, a nightcap at Café Engländer. "To my absolute delight, I often find many of the same old friends sitting in the same old bars and restaurants, talking about the same things with the same sharp humor and cynicism," Hollein says.

Not everything in Vienna is tied to the past. The city's luxury retail landscape expanded last year with the arrival of Austria's first Loewe and Celine boutiques, alongside Dior's 11,000-square-foot shop. The city's museums have followed: The *True Colors* exhibit at the Wien Museum traces four centuries of Viennese fashion, while the Leopold Museum's *Modern Fashion: Wiener Werkstätte & Paris*, set to open in February, will examine how Viennese designers influenced contemporary style. Meanwhile, the MAK Museum of Applied Arts in Vienna has reorganized its entire permanent collection around the fin de siècle moment.

Art remains central to the Vienna experience. Last month the Albertina Museum, celebrating 250 years, opened a major exhibition of Pablo Picasso and Francis Bacon. And the city's local icon, Gustav Klimt, remains everywhere. Guests who book the Klimt Suite at Almanac Palais Vienna can now experience an original Klimt drawing, *Seated Lady from the Front* (1913–1914), in the comfort of their room; enjoy a private two-hour city tour exploring the artist's life; and get exclusive access to the world's largest Klimt collection. Next year marks the 200th anniversary of Beethoven's death, and the city is already planning an ambitious calendar of performances that will once again remind the world why Vienna was Europe's classical music capital.

That may be Vienna's greatest strength. Unlike cities racing to reinvent themselves to claim their share of affluent travelers, Vienna has almost stubbornly refused to change its personality. This is a city that has spent generations perfecting its traditions rather than replacing them. Now seasoned travelers understand exactly what Vienna has known all along: It is beauty made by hand and rituals practiced without irony that keep a city alive.

A bedroom in the Wiener Philharmoniker Suite at the Hotel Sacher.

WIENER MUSIKVEREIN: TERRY LINKE/J. & L. LOBMEYR; HOTEL SACHER: ADRIAN GAUT; REMAINING IMAGES: COURTESY OF THE VENUE AND BRAND.

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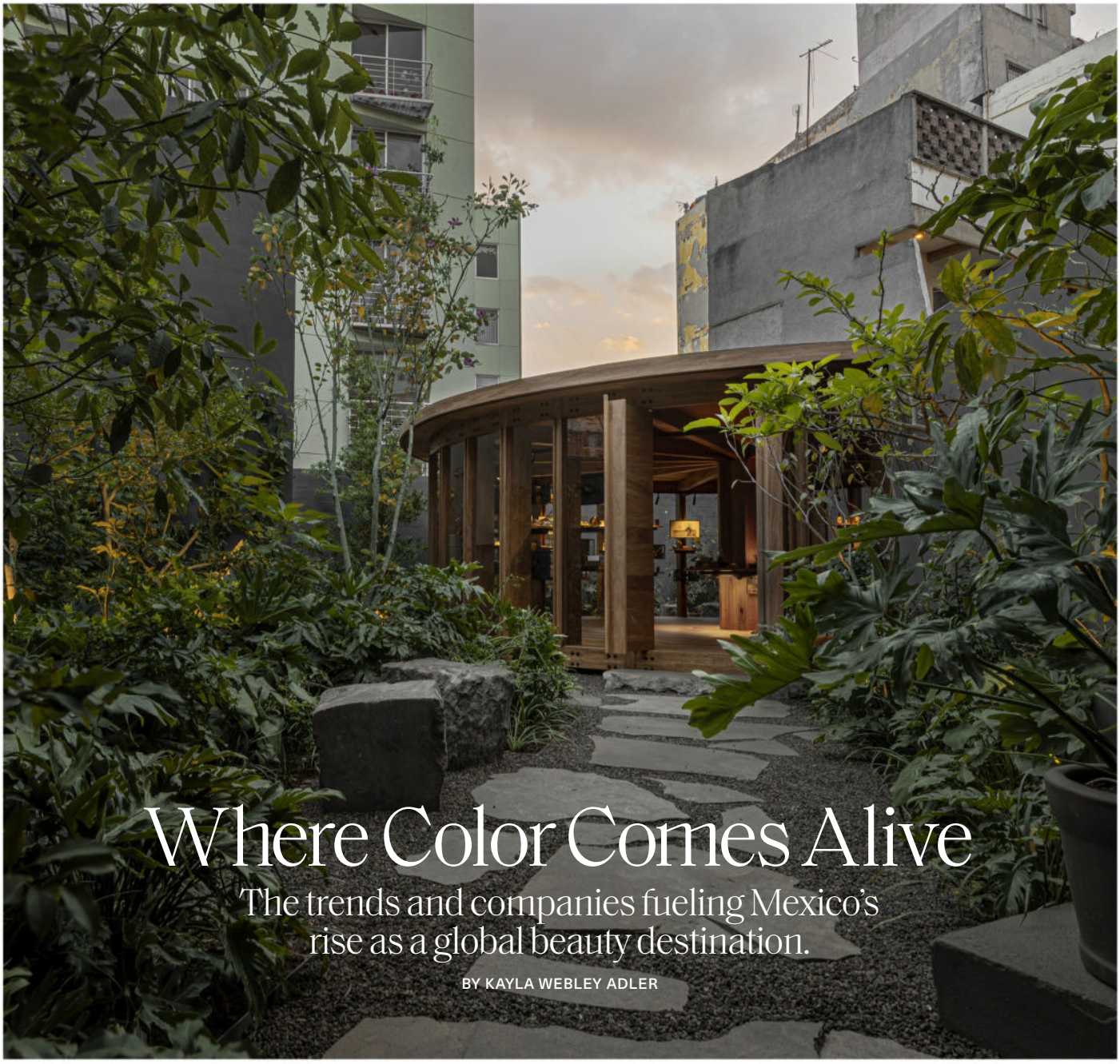
Xinú, the Otomí word for "nose," makes extraordinary perfumes.

IF YOU KNOW YOU KNOW

PHOTOGRAPHED BY JOE LINGEMAN
STYLED BY JOJO LI

Six minutes away from Mexico City's best guava croissants is fragrance heaven. Start on Xinú's garden rooftop, and then venture below to smell creations from famed perfumer Rodrigo Flores-Roux. Xinú's best-selling scent, Aguamadera Xinú Eau de Parfum (xinuperfumes.com) is an ode to agave, with a tart note of lime, salty ocean, and creamy guaiac wood. With a fan base that includes fragrance collectors and Estée Lauder (which invested in the brand last year), Xinú has several stores in Mexico—and its scents are well worth the checked bag.
—KATHLEEN HOU



Where Color Comes Alive

The trends and companies fueling Mexico's rise as a global beauty destination.

BY KAYLA WEBLEY ADLER

When Aora, the beauty brand of choice for Bad Bunny's backup dancers at the Super Bowl, launched online at Sephora in the US this past July, the Mexico City–based company did it with the catchphrase "Hot Like México." The campaign was meant to highlight Aora's viral lip plumping serum, Acaríciame Más, which is infused with five kinds of Mexican chilies, but the line could just as well have been a nod to the country's rising popularity as a global beauty destination.

Aora (a play on *ahora*, the Spanish word for "now") opened its first store in the city's trendy Roma Norte neighborhood in December 2023. At the time, CEO Nour Tayara says he and cofounder Rodrigo Peñafiel were aiming to "give the people what they want—and they wanted Mexico."

Though beauty standards have long been determined by the fashion capitals, Mexico City is increasingly setting trends of its own. "I'm really happy to see that the world is finally taking note, and Mexican beauty is now getting its moment on the stage," says Sandra Lilia Velasquez, CEO and founder of the beauty brand Nopalera. "Because like Paris, Milan, and New York City, Mexico City is part of that list."

"We felt like we were on the cusp, like, 'Wow, this is it.' The city and country were attracting so much attention that imagery of El Ángel de la Independencia, Frida Kahlo's house in Coyoacán, and the boats in Xochimilco started becoming comparable to the

Opposite: Xinú's CDMX store. *This page*: Products from Aora and Nopalera.

Place Vendôme in Paris or the Empire State Building in New York City," Tayara adds. "And when a culture becomes iconic, you want to bottle it and sell it."

Mexican beauty has a distinct look that makes it a destination for lovers of maximalism and sensuality. "People here don't just wear blush, they wear *blush*, and they don't just wear mascara, they wear *mascara*," Velasquez explains. "And that kind of boldness is what's resonating. It's like, yes, let's paint our houses pink and wear blush you can see from across the room." Aora's Mírame eye shadow palette, for example, features the blue of Frida Kahlo's house, the fuchsia-pink hue known as Rosa Mexicano, and a shade of gold that was matched to the 10 cent peso coin. "When you walk in the city, you've got a pink building, next to a blue building, next to a yellow building, and in front is a purple tree," Tayara says. "Mexico, as a country, not only is obsessed with color, but knows color so intrinsically and instinctively."

The company's products are proudly Mexican, with bilingual packaging. Aora's Acaríciame Más utilizes an "ancestral technique of irritating the lips" with spice to plump them. The brand's other viral product is Inicia, a 12-hour illuminating primer that harnesses heritage ingredients like agastache (similar to mint) to soothe the skin, cactus flower extract to hydrate, and tepezcohuite tree extract to support regeneration.

At the same time that home-grown beauty brands have been gaining popularity beyond Mexico's borders, international retailers and brands have been flocking to the country, like Ulta Beauty, which opened its first store in Mexico City in August 2025; and Rhode, Charlotte Tilbury, and Patrick Ta, which entered the Mexican market within the past two years. "Honestly, I'm so freaking happy it's happening, because there were so many brands that we just could not get because we were never the main market," says Anna Sarelly, cofounder and creative director of Sarelly, a Mexico City–based vegan, clean beauty and accessories brand.

Her namesake company opened its flagship store in 2021, also in Roma Norte, with a line of leather bags made from the prickly pear cactus (the same plant seen on Mexico's flag), before entering the beauty market two years later. As a beauty content creator, Sarelly was motivated to expand by the lack of products designed for women like her. "Everything we do is thinking Latina first. It's totally infused from the beginning," she says. "I'm so proud of being Latina, and I don't want to erase that."

The brand's hero product, Cow Lashes Waterproof Mascara, was made for those Latinas who have "super straight, thin, downward-pointing lashes like a cow," Sarelly says, adding, "It's something my granny, my *abuelita*, used to say," with a laugh. Sarelly officially launched in the US in September, at Target stores nationwide.

Another Mexico City brand making an impact far beyond its locale is Xinú, an inventive luxury brand that has PerfumeTok buzzing. Verónica Peña, one of Xinú's three cofounders, says that from the outset, Xinú was designed to travel far beyond its native country. "When we started the company, we said, 'Erase the borders from your mind,' " Peña says. "We are three Mexican founders with a strong connection to Mexico, but we also see ourselves as representing the whole American continent, like a seed traveling, just as scent can travel across borders." Xinú utilizes some Mexican ingredients in its fragrances and is glad to share them with the world. "Just as the French are proud of their lavender," Peña explains, "we are proud of our pink pepper, our marigold, our vanilla, and our tuberose."

XINÚ; ALEJANDRO RAMIREZ OROZCO; REMAINING IMAGES: COURTESY OF THE BRANDS.

Beauty

Mirror Work

SPHINX, SWAROVSKI COLLABORATION FOR BOOK OF DREAMS (2019) BY MARTINE GUTIERREZ; COURTESY OF THE ARTIST, FRAENKEL GALLERY, JOSH LILLEY, AND RYAN LEE GALLERY; *VALENSTEIN* FILM STILLS (2004) BY MARTINE GUTIERREZ; COURTESY OF THE ARTIST, HUIS MARSEILLE, FRAENKEL GALLERY, JOSH LILLEY, AND RYAN LEE GALLERY.

Sphinx, Swarovski collaboration for Book of Dreams (2019) by Martine Gutierrez.

Artist Martine Gutierrez reflects on the stories we're told about beauty. *By Patricia Reynoso*

Martine Gutierrez has spent her career examining the forces that shape how we see ourselves: Who gets to define beauty? Who gets to claim identity? And how much of what we desire is shaped by the images we're taught to admire? Her landmark 2018 project, *Indigenous Woman*—a meticulously produced fashion magazine starring Gutierrez as every model and as editor-in-chief, stylist, and creative director—centered Indigenous and trans identities rarely seen in mainstream media. It later became a solo exhibition and was acquired by the Metropolitan Museum of Art's Costume Institute.

In August, Gutierrez starred in *Marina*, a new live performance co-conceived with writer, director, and comedian Julio Torres that was commissioned as part of the 2026 Whitney Biennial. Gutierrez spoke with ELLE about why beauty has become a focus in her work, what she learned after stepping inside the glamorous world she once idolized, and why she's now embracing the creative possibilities of letting go.

When did your Maya heritage become such an important part of your artistic language, particularly in *Indigenous Woman*?

Indigenous Woman happened as a question for me. When you're a kid, you question who you are. And when you're of mixed heritage—my mom is American, my dad is from Guatemala, and his mother is Maya—that question becomes: Can I claim this? Can I claim either word? Can I claim being a woman, and can I claim being Indigenous as someone who was born a little boy in America? I never seem to be Indigenous enough, and I never seem to be American enough.

What drew you to magazines as a storytelling format?

I've seen more magazines than museums. The arts made me feel estranged. There's something precious about art. You can't touch it—you need a certain distance from it. When I made *Indigenous Woman*, it wasn't something you had to visit in a museum. It was meant to be flipped through and held. There is also a similarity between a gallery and a magazine. There's a pacing. It's an art show without a white box.

Your 2022 *Supremacy* billboard depicted you reclining in white lace lingerie while surrounded by Barbie-like dolls. Upon closer inspection, it's clear that the dolls are trying to pin you down. How intentional is that split second when someone mistakes one of your works for an ad?

That feels like a win. That feels like winning the World Cup. But I never know if it's going to happen. Some people don't look. Or they look, but they don't see. I look like so many people who already fit a certain beauty standard—and because I'm making myself look like them, there's this moment of recognition. The references feel familiar, too: "I've seen this before...but I haven't." Hopefully that's why people do the double take. They catch a clue that something is a little different. I don't think we're taught to read images critically.

How did you learn what beauty meant?

I didn't grow up with people telling me I was beautiful. It's so corny, but your flaws are your flaws, and accepting the things that make you different is what makes you beautiful. Recently, my mother said something that really stayed with me. She told me it was the person I was—not my physicality—that allowed me to do all of this. I think that's partly why beauty has become such a focus in my work. Even when I photograph other people, I'm looking for that unexpected thing that makes them beautiful. My friends will often say, "That's the best I've ever looked." I think I've trained my eye to find beauty where people don't always expect it—and to help the viewer see it, too.

What does glamour mean to you, and how has that changed?

I believed there was something glamorous about being draped in a designer dress. I believed I'd finally be beautiful if Pat McGrath did my makeup. Then she did do my makeup. It was for a Club Glam event, when her brand finally launched at Sephora. But when it was time for my scene, I couldn't stop crying, because it was my turn and I flopped. I didn't have what it takes. The more that I was in the fashion world, the more I felt critical of it. There is a meme of a girl auditioning for *America's Next Top Model* who walks into the casting and then says, "I just don't think this is right for me. I don't want to do it. I want to go home." Then she shuffles out before they can even judge her. That's who I identify with.

You've begun expanding beyond photography into performance, film, music, and theater. What has stepping beyond the still image opened up for you?

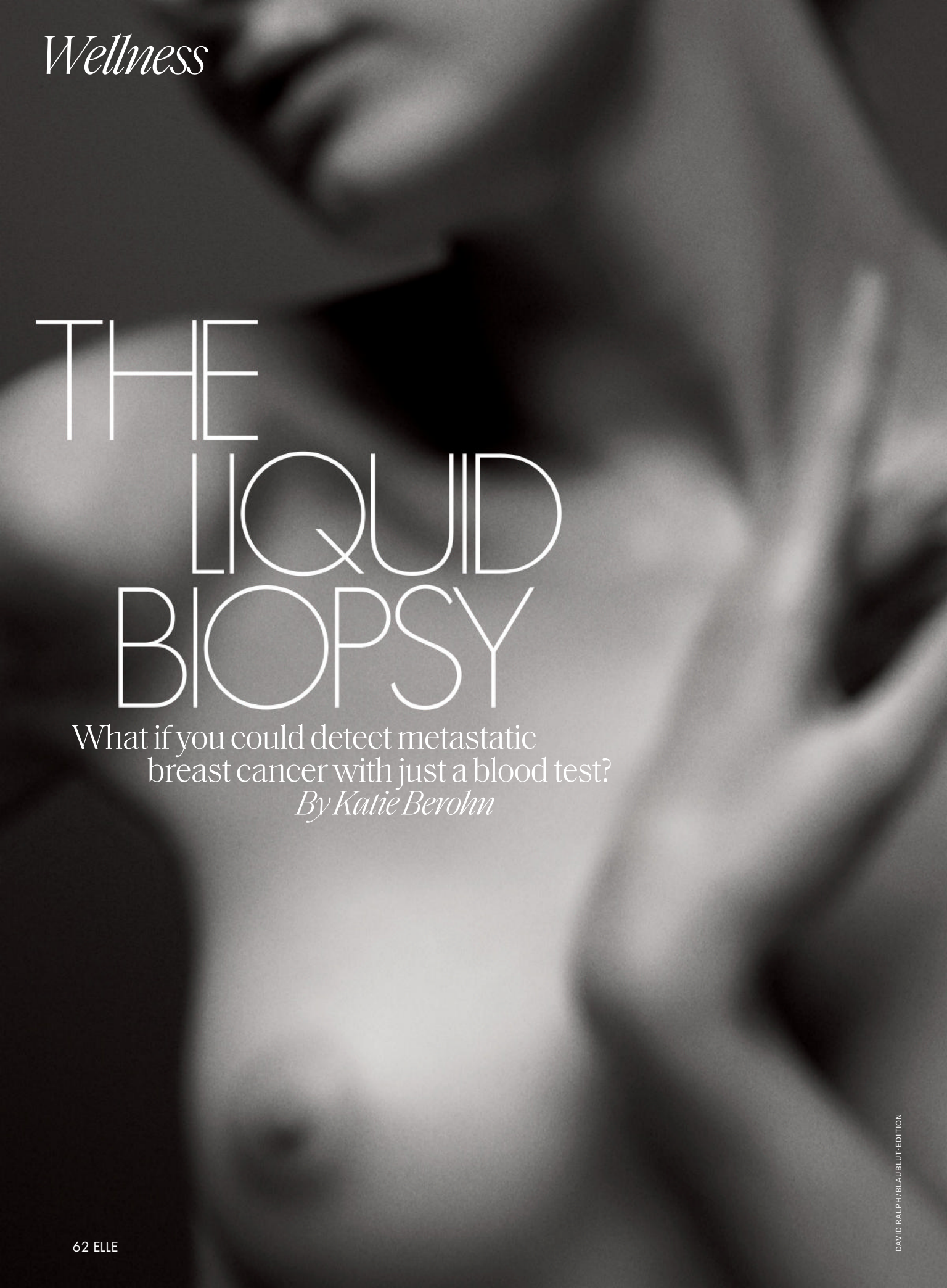
I don't know. And I think it's the not knowing that's really exciting. It feels like anything is possible. So much of my work has been me sitting in front of my own camera. It's also my inability to give up control. It's an Achilles' heel as much as it's been a strength. I'm trying to get over standing in my own way. I don't want it to become a crutch. I'm not really interested in having a career. I'm interested in living a life that's interesting.

Film stills from *Valenstein* (2004).

THE LIQUID BIOPSY

What if you could detect metastatic breast cancer with just a blood test?

By Katie Berohn



DAVID RALPH/BLAUBLUT-EDITION

Justine Morris was 28 when she discovered a lump in her breast, and 30 when doctors pronounced her cancer-free. But after Morris's treatment had ended, every minor symptom caused panic: Was it a cold? Was she under the weather? Or had her cancer returned? "Because I have the BRCA2 gene, I have a higher chance of the cancer coming back," she says. "The type I had was fast-moving and aggressive." For patients like Morris, the uncertainty is a dreadful waiting game with physical exams, symptom monitoring, and yearly mammograms to detect any rogue cancer cells left behind after treatment. But she also does something more cutting edge: Every three months, she has her blood drawn and sent to a lab for monitoring.

Morris is an early adopter of circulating tumor DNA (ctDNA) blood tests, offered through tests like Signatera as well as those from Personalis, as part of her breast cancer screening tool kit. Nearly 30 percent of women diagnosed with early-stage breast cancer will end up developing metastatic breast cancer, meaning it has spread to other parts of the body. Once cancer spreads, it is considered stage IV, and while treatable, it is incurable. Body scans can't catch stray cancer cells early, and aren't often used as a monitoring tool for some types of breast cancer. "In general, we don't scan people proactively," says Elisa Port, MD, a breast surgeon and author of *The Breast Advice: All You Need to Know About Breast Health, Screening, and Treatment*. "Because unfortunately, there is no such thing as early stage IV disease."

But what if there was an easy way to detect a recurrence earlier? Doctors, researchers, and patients hope that ctDNA tests could hold the key. These tests, known as liquid biopsies, analyze a patient's blood to find residual cancer cells. They work by targeting someone's specific tumor DNA. "We take the patient's tumor, sequence it, and then look for mutations in the blood," explains Ben Ho Park, MD, PhD, a Breast Cancer Research Foundation (BCRF) scientist.

"Tumors shed pieces of their DNA into our blood," says Dorraya El-Ashry, PhD, chief scientific officer at BCRF. For a long time, ctDNA tests were not considered sensitive enough to detect that infinitesimal amount of cancer DNA and residual disease. It's harder than finding a needle in a haystack—it's like finding just the eye of it. But thanks to evolving biotech breakthroughs, the current generation of tests is equipped for the search. "It's like more shots on goal," Park says. "These tests can detect one cancer DNA molecule out of a million. The older-gen tests were a hundredfold less sensitive—one in 10,000."

In a study published in the *Journal of Clinical Oncology* this past March, Park and his team were able to determine the accuracy of an ultrasensitive ctDNA test from Personalis. Over the course of five years, doctors monitored 228 cancer survivors using ctDNA tests. Patients with triple-negative breast cancer who still had detectable ctDNA after surgery and other therapies were 128 times more likely to have their cancer return. "I had a young woman, a mother of two children, who had a little smidgen of one of her tumors [showing up in a blood test]," Park says. Her scans hadn't showed anything metastatic, but based on the information from the ctDNA, Park put her on an anticancer drug, and her scans have been clear now for 18 months and counting.

The next-gen tests are still in clinical trials, but a few are available for patients like Morris to use ahead of full FDA approval, with Medicare covering the cost for some cases. Signatera, in particular, is already pre-market-approved for specific use cases like muscle-invasive bladder cancer. Still, some doctors are hesitant to introduce ctDNA tests quite yet to monitor for recurrences in people who have had breast cancer. The technology is "very promising," Port says, "but it is not yet proven to be ready for prime time. So what if you do a ctDNA test and it shows circulating tumor cells? Are you going to start someone on aggressive treatment based on those results alone?" In order for a ctDNA test to become standard, researchers will need to do more clinical testing to prove "beyond a shadow of a doubt" that it can actually extend a patient's lifespan, Park says. And while researchers haven't yet cleared that bar, Park and El-Ashry are both hopeful that in certain cases, more breast cancer survivors could be using the tests in the future.

Until there is a clear blueprint for introducing blood tests into cancer care, doctors will still follow standard screening and prevention protocols as well. And Port stresses the importance of sticking to the treatment plan recommended after surgery, since not doing so can up the risk of recurrence and potential metastatic disease.

Could tests like these become commonplace as preventive tools to detect recurrences of many kinds of cancer? We're not quite there yet, but it's possible. A trial conducted by the health care company GRAIL in partnership with the UK National Health Service did not prove that its multi-cancer early detection ctDNA test, Galleri, was able to find cancers before they are classified as stage III or IV (which was the end goal), but it did show that three years of screening cut the number of cancers found at stage IV in each sequential year. Park feels hopeful that we might see these tools used in clinical settings within 10 years or so as tests continue to improve.

In the meantime, the so-called liquid biopsies offer a glimmer of hope for cancer patients at a moment when they might otherwise feel totally in the dark. "I cannot tell you the mental weight of being a cancer patient and noticing everything about your body—the aches, the pains," Morris says. "Do I need to go get a scan? Now I have a built-in system in place where I know that I'm okay. I know if I do feel an ache or a pain, I'm getting a Signatera test in X amount of time, and I'm okay to wait until then. And that has been really helpful."

"It's like more shots on goal. These tests can detect one cancer DNA molecule out of a million."

—BEN HO PARK, MD, PHD

Yes, And!

Two classmates–turned–business partners are *reimagining the world of architectural design.*

BY VÉRONIQUE HYLAND
PHOTOGRAPHED BY RONA LIANA AHDOUT

It had been a long quarantine fall, and Ana Amelia Batlle Cabral was growing weary of taking all her classes on Zoom. So she messaged everyone in her class at the Yale School of Architecture asking if anyone would be up for meeting in person. One classmate, Signe Randolph Ferguson, took her up on the offer, inviting her over for a home-cooked meal, and they became instant friends.

The two bonded further when they began traveling together as part of their studies—to Rome, Greenland, and Mexico. Ferguson recalls that they became teary-eyed in Greenland as they beheld melting icebergs, which she poetically refers to as "climate metronomes." They started design projects in tandem, too, turning a room on campus into an hourglass and filling it with sand ("much to the dismay of the amazing curatorial staff," Ferguson says) as well as setting off a fire alarm during an immersive sound performance.

The dynamic between them is immediately clear—Ferguson is the sunny, chatty one with an absurdist sense of humor (she bills herself on Instagram as "The Youngest Woman Alive"), while Cabral is more reserved, carefully calibrating her responses. Cabral has a penchant for the fantastical—she grew up enthralled by the tales of mythological creatures in her native Dominican Republic, like La Ciguapa, usually depicted as a woman with backward feet. Ferguson's interests skew more earthbound. When she was growing up in Houston and New York City, her mother, a doctor-turned-artist, gave her tools like sand and Legos to create miniature landscapes. As ELLE editors set up for the pair's photo shoot, her attention alights on a clothing rack, and she begins spitballing about how it could be redesigned for maximum efficiency.

Post-graduation, Cabral began working for the architect Frida Escobedo, while Ferguson worked for the artist Pedro Reyes and the architect Tatiana Bilbao. They also formed their own studio, BASA Atelier, which stands for "Batlle and Sig and ___," with the idea that other collaborators can cycle through. Their focus, Ferguson says, is "serious playing," and it spills outside traditional architecture to encompass everything from furniture to set design to land art.

Cabral sums up their attitude as "*Sí a todo*," or "Yes to everything." Among their current and upcoming projects:

Cabral (left) and Ferguson at BAS Stone in Long Island City, Queens.

a mobile installation in Mexico City for the handbag label Audette; crafting sculptures for a private home in Majorca; designing a retail space for the textile and homeware brand Onora's new London store; and creating several furniture lines of their own. Their talents are not limited to the built environment; after our interview, they send me an abstract drawing to represent our conversation, something Ferguson says they typically do for people they connect with.

Whatever their medium, the two are hyper-focused on the human element. Cabral says the duo is constantly asking themselves, "How do I feel when I stand here? What do I want to see? What specific memories or moments do we want people to leave with?" Adds Ferguson, "Sometimes Ana will put a rock in the sun to make sure that we know what the material is going to do at a certain point in the day." The two can go from the terrestrial (like rhapsodizing about orange travertine, which they're using in a land art project) to the conceptual (like talking about the design ideas of minimalist touchstone Donald Judd), almost within the same sentence.

Seamlessly incorporating the surrounding environment is always part of the duo's practice, especially since they've seen how extractive industrial architecture can be. Like "Leave no trace" hikers, they aim to not disturb the local environment, and instead work in concert with it (for example, they have a general rule that materials should be sourced from within a 50-kilometer radius, though there are some exceptions). A recent project allowed them to put those principles into action. The architectural firm ROSCH—which helms an effort in which 390-square-meter cube-shaped structures are built across Latin America—called on them to design one in Nagua, an underserved community in the Dominican Republic. The communities themselves, working with a nonprofit organization called Arcoíris, determine the structures' use—resulting in everything from a school to a computer room. The cubic building they designed as a community center was made with coralina, a stone that is found naturally in the region, with the goal, Cabral says, that "it would merge and become invisible [against] the landscape."

> "In the age of starchitects, you're sold *this false idea of one person* getting something done [all alone]. We're happy to be candid about the fact that *it actually needs this magic mixture.*"
>
> —SIGNE RANDOLPH FERGUSON

The architecture world still has some auteurist, male-centered preoccupations—though Cabral and Ferguson tell me they have had largely positive experiences in the field, and in fact work with a predominantly female team. Ferguson compares their approach to a film, where everyone gets acknowledged when the credits roll. They always cite their collaborators publicly and, when working with artisans, have them sign the pieces. "Sometimes, in the age of starchitects, you're sold this false idea of one person getting something done [all alone]," she says. "We're happy to be candid about the fact that it actually needs this magic mixture. We're not just trying to pour one of ourselves out onto the table."

Midnight Juaracan Chairs by BASA Atelier.

Both women are currently working full-time at BASA, with Cabral based in New York and the Dominican Republic, and Ferguson in London and Mexico City, managing projects across multiple time zones, including two land art projects in Majorca and a building in Mexico City. ("We both have partners who are constantly like, 'I did not realize how much architects work,'" Ferguson says of their significant others.) Cabral is also juggling an increased public profile that has seen her attend the Met Gala with her partner, *Saturday Night Live* cast member Marcello Hernández. "It's super inspiring to be in those settings, because I'm around the most talented people in the field," she says. "There's a saying in Spanish, '*Dime con quién te juntas y te diré quién eres*,' which is kind of like, 'Tell me who you're hanging out with and I'll tell you who you are.'

"The public life I'm still getting used to," she adds, "but also, if I'm not at an event, it's not like people are stopping me on the street."

The cross-pollination of their worlds seems to have stirred Cabral's and Ferguson's imaginations even more. With the zeal of the architecture students they once were, they tell me about all the fields they want to dip their toes into. Cabral invokes Salvador Dalí, who worked with fashion designers and beauty brands, as one inspiration. She also has a vision of creating a land art park in the Dominican Republic. "It's an economy that's based on tourism, and tourists usually only go to the all-inclusive resorts and stay on the beach," she says. "If there are other ways to pull people from all over the world to come and see the land, then I think art is a powerful tool to allow for that....That's one of our dreams." Knowing them, it won't be long before it becomes a reality.

STYLED BY CARSON STANNARD; HAIR BY ALINA FRIESEN FOR LIVING PROOF; MAKEUP BY DANI PARKES AT THE WALL GROUP. CHAIRS: COURTESY OF THE BRAND.

CAPTURING CASTRO

Diego Boneta enlisted an acting coach, a history professor, and three dialect tutors to help him channel the Cuban dictator.

BY TOMÁS MIER

Diego Boneta's Cuban friends were adamant: "Don't play Fidel. It's way too risky. He's our Hitler. Don't do it," his friends told him when they heard he had been cast to play the authoritarian leader in *Killing Castro*, the film, also starring Al Pacino, that premiered at the Tribeca Festival this summer. But despite the warnings—or maybe because of them—Boneta did it anyway. "From the very beginning, I knew what this meant—how serious it was for what Fidel represents," Boneta says. "I understood what that responsibility meant."

American audiences might know Boneta for playing lighter roles in 2012's *Rock of Ages* or in 2015's *Scream Queens*, but the Mexican heartthrob was excited by the challenge of embodying the Communist dictator with a complicated history. "I was very scared at first—I'm not gonna lie," Boneta tells me from an apartment in New York City, where he appears clean-shaven, without the wiry mustache that he grew for the role. "It's the biggest challenge I've ever had as an actor, and also the most rewarding one. But I didn't know that when I first decided to jump in."

Boneta is no stranger to playing real-life characters. He last starred as the Mexican singer Luis Miguel in the hit Netflix series of the same name, which gave Boneta, who wanted to be a singer before he got pulled into telenovela acting as a teen, the opportunity to show off his singing chops. Still, playing Castro presented an entirely new hurdle. "His voice was very particular," Boneta says. "He made very specific sounds, and he had a particular cadence."

For nearly three years, Boneta obsessively transformed himself into character for the political thriller, loosely based on actual events, that follows the Cuban leader's 1960 visit to New York City to address the United Nations, where an

BONETA: ACKIME SNOW; *KILLING CASTRO* STILL: COURTESY OF ROMULUS ENTERTAINMENT.

undercover CIA agent (played by Pacino) is sent to assassinate him. "As an actor, you have to justify it, you can't judge it. The second you start judging it, you're fucked," Boneta says of preparing to play the polarizing political figure. "You need to be the best lawyer for your character. And instead of being like, 'Oh, that's fucked up,' you have to understand where that comes from and why he did it. So that it's not just, '*Soy el malo de malolandia*' (I'm the bad guy from bad guy land)."

Onscreen, Boneta says he wanted to embody Castro completely, focusing on how the Cuban leader "oozed charisma" every time he spoke. He says he also tried to inhabit the physicality of the 6′3″ "tank" Castro was in real life, wearing a bodysuit to bulk up his 5′11″ frame, broadening his arms to demonstrate. For his delivery, Boneta says he drew inspiration from Forest Whitaker's Oscar-winning portrayal of Idi Amin in *The Last King of Scotland*.

Boneta took advantage of production delays on the film to prepare, enlisting the acting coach he's worked with for over a decade (and shares with Javier Bardem and Penélope Cruz); a Cuban history professor to teach him "what they don't teach you in school" about Castro; and three dialect tutors—one for his specific regional Cuban Spanish, another to help with his delivery in English, and a third who taught him the cadence for a lengthy, "very Mussolini-esque" monologue that serves as the centerpiece of the film. "I'm a very obsessive guy," he explains, adding that he played Castro's speeches on loop for hours every day on his iPad to master his mannerisms. "I'm very obsessive when it comes to preparation, especially for a role like this." (The prep paid off even in the smallest details, like wearing two watches on the same arm—a Castro quirk he nailed after his friend, the director Alfonso Cuarón, told him, "Don't forget the two Rolexes on the wrist.")

> "Imagine if someone told 12-year-old Dieguito, 'In 20 years, you're going to work with Al Pacino.' I never would have believed it."

The most rewarding part of the *Killing Castro* experience, he says, came from working alongside Hollywood royalty—Pacino—even though they're never onscreen at the same time. Days before the film premiered at Tribeca in June, Boneta got to deliver a lifetime achievement trophy to Pacino at an event hosted by Tiffany & Co. It was an emotional full-circle moment for Boneta, who grew up watching *The Godfather* with his father and credits Pacino's performance as the reason he wanted to act. The tears came when Pacino went from gratitude to unexpectedly praising Boneta's performance in the film during his acceptance speech. "I can say that I can die a happy man," Boneta tells me of that moment. "I never thought that he was going to even talk about my performance....Having someone like Al say that is one of the best things that's ever happened to me."

That kind of Hollywood validation is a long way from Boneta's beginnings. For a generation of Mexicans, Boneta is the equivalent of a Disney Channel star who made it big. He starred in a hit kids' telenovela, *Alegrijes y Rebujos*, at 13, before joining *Rebelde*, the teen telenovela that spawned a real-life pop band, RBD. Boneta joined the band on tour as a guest while launching his solo music career, which eventually yielded two studio albums. "Music was my first love. Back then, I was really doing the acting thing so I could launch my solo album," he says. "I fell in love with acting, but it was by accident." He says there was no better education than working on a telenovela. "When you're doing telenovelas, you're shooting 30 scenes a day," he says. "It's an unbelievable school, because it teaches you to really learn how to take direction, because they're not going to give you five takes."

Boneta revisited those memories recently on a visit to his childhood home in Mexico City. "The family who bought the house when we moved out was still there, and I was able to go inside for the first time in 20 years," Boneta says of the spontaneous visit. "*No había cambiado nada* (nothing had changed). It smelled the same, it looked the same. It was as if I walked back in time." As he walked through the rooms, he looked out the windows and reflected on how much things had changed for him. "Imagine if someone told 12-year-old Dieguito, 'In 20 years, you're going to work with Al Pacino,'" he says. "I never would have believed it."

Now, firmly seated at the Hollywood table, Boneta is creating his own opportunities, and bringing Mexico with him. His next major project is the Prime Video series *El Gato*, based on the 1993 comic book *El Gato Negro*, a bilingual superhero drama. Boneta will star as Francisco "Frank" Guerrero, a man who returns home to Mexico and discovers his father was a 1970s vigilante. The series, which Boneta is also executive producing through his company Three Amigos, has been a passion project since 2018 (or as he puts it, "That's my baby").

El Gato serves as the perfect counterprogramming to the heavy, politically fraught endeavor of playing Castro. Boneta says the action-packed show is "a love letter to Mexico." There's also the novel he published last year, *The Undoing of Alejandro Velasco*, which is being turned into a film, and he's already manifesting what he'll do next. There are no music projects on the horizon, but his first love always sneaks back in. "I would love to do Broadway," he says. "Music is *mi primer amor*. I started my career singing, I love singing, and it always finds its way back to me."

Boneta in a scene from *Killing Castro*.

The entryway to Cantina Contramar in the Fontainebleau Las Vegas.

EXPORTING AN ICON

Nearly 30 years after opening Contramar, chef Gabriela Cámara reimagines her landmark restaurant—with a few friends.

BY ADRIENNE GAFFNEY

How do you translate a national favorite to a new country? It's a tricky proposition. Contramar has been famous as one of the most celebrated restaurants in Mexico since chef and owner Gabriela Cámara opened it in 1998 in the capital city. With its fan-favorite tuna tostadas and signature red and green grilled fish, the seafood restaurant revolutionized the Mexican dining scene, where at the time, restaurants were typically either high-end or very casual. The aim, Cámara says, was to give city dwellers the fresh fish associated with the coast. "Restaurants were much more divided by geography, by the location, by the pricing," Cámara explains of the pre-Contramar scene. "Contramar, even though it isn't a place where anybody can go, is a place where food is accessible. It's an easy, homey, everyday-ish place—and festive, reminiscent of a beach shack." Now, nearly 30 years later, having become a bona fide international culinary star, Cámara has decided to bring the seaside vibes to a new city: Las Vegas.

The kitchen and dining room of the new Cantina Contramar.

The journey began several years ago, when her friend Bertha González Nieves, cofounder and CEO of the Mexican tequila brand Casa Dragones, met Brett Mufson, president and partner of Fontainebleau Development (the company that owns the Fontainebleau hotel locations in Miami Beach and Las Vegas), at Art Basel. Mufson told González Nieves that he would love to bring a Mexico City hot spot to Las Vegas. González Nieves took him to Contramar and introduced him to Cámara, beginning a relationship that led to Cantina Contramar opening in the Fontainebleau Las Vegas.

To create the first Contramar outside of Mexico, Cámara worked alongside two other Mexican women who've become internationally known in their fields: Frida Escobedo, the influential architect working on a new wing of the Metropolitan Museum of Art and the Centre Pompidou's renovation project, designed the restaurant's chic, modern space, while González Nieves collaborated on the drinks menu. "Bertha was the one to actually make this happen. And Frida and

> "The American way of eating has expanded greatly, and people are looking for more far-out cuisines."
>
> —GABRIELA CÁMARA

I have been friends for quite some time," Cámara explains. "I said [to Frida], 'I know it's crazy to do something in Las Vegas, but would you be willing?'" Escobedo said yes right away.

Cantina Contramar is the rare restaurant project to be helmed by three women, but for Cámara, who served as a food policy adviser to former Mexican president Andrés Manuel López Obrador, and was the subject of the 2019 Netflix documentary *A Tale of Two Kitchens*, about the opening of her former San Francisco restaurant Cala, it isn't unusual. "Women have always cooked in Mexico, so it isn't an anomaly," she explains. She was pleased to find a similar dynamic in Las Vegas: "I was very pleasantly surprised at how many wonderful and powerful women run the shows there. It's still a very male-run place, but I do think that women in this industry have had the opportunity to really make a difference."

Cámara says the Vegas location translates the original Contramar, adjusting for the American palate without sacrificing its spirit. "The American way of eating has expanded greatly, and I think people are looking for more far-out cuisines that they weren't familiar with a few years ago," Cámara says. The menu is comprehensive, she says, and will appeal to many different kinds of diners. New dishes have been added, including a steak and a few taco options.

There are differences between the two Contramars—a luxe casino was never going to have the homey feeling of a beach shack. The dining room is large and airy, with a communal atmosphere. As in the original, there's an open kitchen where diners can watch the chefs work. The interior design features volcanic stone, hammered copper, and onyx panels that give the room a rosy glow; the result is an elegant, not necessarily Las Vegas look that incorporates elements of Mexican design. "We're carrying that flag and that baton for people falling in love with our country, whether it's in architecture or culinary hospitality or agave spirits," González Nieves says. "There's so much passion that came together in this team."

A private dining room at the new restaurant.

Contramar chef and owner Gabriela Cámara.

CANTINA CONTRAMAR (3): MAUREEN EVANS; CÁMARA: RENE VILLASEÑOR.

Allende photographed at her home in 2023.

"THERE ARE STORIES IN THE AIR"

In a conversation with Eva Longoria, *the legendary author* Isabel Allende explains why she was driven to write her new memoir, *Story Telling*.

BY LAUREN PUCKETT-POPE

MAX FARAGO

After Isabel Allende finished the first draft of her 1982 debut novel, *The House of the Spirits*—pages that nearly became trash in a landfill, an outcome that might have changed the course of her life forever—it didn't take long for her life to change anyway. By that point, Allende was already a journalist, enchanted with the written word for as long as she could remember. But it wasn't until she was nearly 40 years old that she published *The House of the Spirits*, a work that began as a letter to her aging grandfather. The book's success launched Allende on a four-decade trajectory during which she'd release more than 30 books and become one of the most celebrated and widely read authors around the globe. "The truth is that if I didn't write, my soul will shrivel," Allende recounts in her latest release, the memoir–meets–master class *Story Telling: A Writing Life*. "That's why I have written so many books: I can't stop."

Now living in Northern California, the 84-year-old Allende is still keen to reach new audiences with her work. A poignant recent example: the Prime Video series adaptation of *The House of the Spirits*, a saga drawn from Allende's memories of the political upheaval in her childhood home of Chile, after she'd fled to Venezuela in the wake of the 1973 military coup led by Augusto Pinochet. Executive produced by actress, director, and entrepreneur Eva Longoria—alongside Courtney Saladino, Allende, and others—the show debuted in April to critical acclaim.

A few months later, Longoria joined Allende for a vibrant conversation celebrating *Story Telling* and Allende's equally storied career. Throughout their discussion, Allende underscored the same point made throughout her memoir: that even in our era of transformative technology, narrative remains essential. "They say that fiction is in danger of extinction," she writes. "I don't believe that. Today more people consume fiction than ever before. It is possible that the form will change....The form is not relevant; the content will always exist. We need stories, that's why I love the craft of the raconteur."

EVA LONGORIA: You are such an inspiration to people like me. People do think women get put on a shelf at 40. Now maybe it's 50, but we [feel like we] have an expiration date.

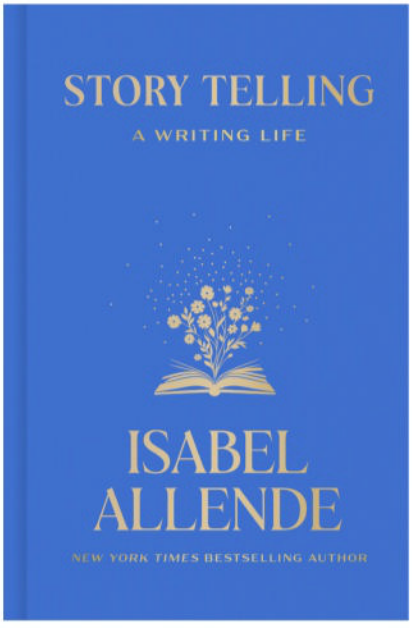
ISABEL ALLENDE: You're right. But you know what? I'm 84 and I don't feel—

EL: What? I thought you were 74!

IA: No, I'm 84. And I feel that I still have a lot to do, you know?

EL: I read *The House of the Spirits* more than 20 years ago, and it really was one of the first books I enjoyed reading. I was not a reader. I did not enjoy reading anything. And that was the first book I couldn't put down. I felt like I identified with these women.

IA: I wrote that book in 1981 on the kitchen counter in my apartment in Caracas. I was living in exile. And at that time, there was no internet and I didn't have an assistant. I worked 12 hours



a day at another job. So I had my little portable typewriter in the kitchen, and there I wrote one copy because putting carbon paper in to make a second copy was so messy that you couldn't correct anything. So you had to think about every sentence before you typed.

That one copy was like a newborn child. I put it in a canvas bag and carried it everywhere. I would take it to my job or leave it in my drawer in my desk, and I'd be aware of where it was at all times.

One day I brought it to the hairdresser, and I had my bag with me when I got a call that my son had fallen at school and broken his arm. So I left in a hurry, and I forgot the bag. That evening I remembered, but it was already night and the place was closed. The next day, I went running back, and the cleaning lady had thrown it away. And so I got into the trash container and got my bag back.

EL: You and I are both outspoken in our political beliefs, and I think that's what drew me to *The House of the Spirits*, [because of how it recounted] the revolution and this moment in Chilean history and how women had such an important role. Did you find it important to create these characters because of this experience that you had?

IA: What had happened in Chile was very present in my life. I lived there during the military coup and for a year after the coup. So I knew how terror feels—what it is to think that you live in a country and in 24 hours it changes completely. You take for granted the freedom of the press, that you can say whatever you want. It's like health—you take it for granted until you get something really serious, and then you realize how precious it is.

So when I see, in the United States, people flirting with an authoritarian government, with the idea of someone being like a king in this country, which is supposed to be the only democracy in the world that was created on an idea, on a philosophical way of seeing what life could be....That wonderful idea has to be defended. And some people think that they can just play around and risk what we have. And I have lived it, so I know how easily it can be taken away, how fragile the institutions are, and how easily you can control people with fear. So that worries me terribly.

EL: I agree with you completely. Democracy is very fragile, and we have to fight for it every day. My next question is, do you have a favorite book of yours that you've written?

IA: *The House of the Spirits*, because it paved the way for all my books and changed my life. It gave me a voice. It connected me with millions of people. It has inspired other creators. I'm so grateful to that book that I feel it was sort of dictated from the beyond, because I had no idea what writing a book was all about. I had no plan, no script, nothing. I was just remembering my relatives. I mean, with a family like mine, you don't need to invent anything.

EL: Do you feel like, at this moment in the world we're living in, there's still a power in narrative? CONTINUED ON PAGE 107

JULIA GARNER *Bets on Herself*

With *The Altruists*, the risk-taking star takes her *appetite for transformation to a new extreme. By Logan Hill*

Photographed by ALLAN HAMITOUCHE *Styled by* PAUL SINCLAIRE

Dress, SCHIAPARELLI COUTURE.

Dress, MAISON MARGIELA.

Dress, RAHUL MISHRA COUTURE. Heels, MATIÈRES FÉCALES FOR CHRISTIAN LOUBOUTIN.

Dress, VIKTOR & ROLF.

Jacket, dress,
STANDING GROUND
COUTURE.

NESTLED IN A LEATHER DINING BOOTH at Little Dom's, perhaps the New Yorkiest Italian bistro in Los Angeles, Julia Garner succinctly explains the difference between her hometown and her home here: "A friend told me, 'New York is fun hell. And LA is sad heaven.' "

Garner, the shape-shifting star of *Ozark*, *Inventing Anna*, *Weapons*, and the new Netflix series *The Altruists*, casts her piercing blue eyes toward a photo of Ava Gardner on the restaurant wall, one of the classic stars Garner grew up watching on TV with her family in the Riverdale neighborhood of the Bronx. As her own star rose, she moved to LA six years ago. But now she's having second thoughts. "In New York, you have to think so fast that you're forced to be present," says Garner, dressed Cali-casual in jeans and a striped long-sleeved tee. "Here, you don't have a sense of time so much. The weather's the same. There are no seasons. So you, like, daydream more...."

Only, daydreaming by the pool is not her jam. "We burn," she says, laughing as she touches her pale arms. "I really should be a vampire, because I'm, like, allergic to the sun."

Then there's the restless New York striver energy that seems coiled inside her, ready to spring like her signature blond curls. Garner admits that she does not like to sit still, and doesn't take many days off anyway. "Since January, I've been working almost every day," she says, smiling and not at all complaining. "The more time goes on, I just kind of want to push it even more, and more, and more."

Over lunch, Garner even seems restless with being herself. At moments when she speaks, I hear hints of the crass Missouri twang of *Ozark*'s Ruth Langmore, a role for which she won three Emmys, and the lurid Russo-Euro patois of *Inventing Anna*'s grifting fake heiress Anna Delvey, which launched a million memes. The actress, 32, has been burning up the screen for half her life, in one transformative, go-for-broke performance after another. She debuted at 16 as a cult initiate in *Martha Marcy May Marlene*, then played another cult member, then a cannibal, and then, in a move that most actors would never dare, the employee of a lecherous movie producer boss in *The Assistant*. When she finally did a mainstream blockbuster in *Fantastic Four: First Steps*, she was unrecognizable as the metal-skinned alien Silver Surfer, and immediately followed it up with Zach Cregger's wild horror hit *Weapons*, as a teacher accused of being a child-murdering witch. In the last year, she wrapped *The Altruists* in Vancouver, shot an arc on *The Studio* in Venice with her new bestie Madonna (more on that later), then hurried to shoot the film *Tyrant* with Charlize Theron and Demi Moore—and developed yet another upcoming series, Apple TV's *Guilty Creatures*, via her own production company.

So, no. Maybe the laid-back heaven of California is not for her. Garner says she misses New York's breakneck energy, and wants to be closer to family and friends. (She does not say she wants a fresh start after her recent split from her husband of over six years, musician Mark Foster of Foster the People. When I ask if she'd like to talk about her separation, she looks at me like, "Are you crazy?" Then she politely declines.)

"Yeah, I think I'll move back to New York." Probably the Upper West Side. "Anywhere except for Murray Hill. No shade against Murray Hill, but...shade against Murray Hill."

New York is, appropriately enough, where Netflix's *The Altruists* begins. The series plays as a spectacularly nerdy love story, telling the true-life saga of FTX crypto exchange cofounder Sam Bankman-Fried and his partner in business, crime, and polyamory, Caroline Ellison, a mousy math whiz who bears almost zero resemblance to the woman sitting across from me. Their meet-cute is a hedge fund job interview, in which Sam underestimates Caroline until she correctly analyzes the risks of our winner-take-all world and concludes, "Going all in every time is the mathematically optimal strategy."

"I can tell when people phone it in. For me, if I'm gonna do it half-ass, *I'd rather just not do it.*"

Sam, played by the Irish actor Anthony Boyle, swoons: She had him at *mathematically*. The two fall in love, bonded by the idealistic conviction that the optimal way to do good in the world is to make as much money as possible, then give it away. (Spoiler alert: They're better at the former than the latter.) The two double down until they have defrauded FTX crypto customers of $8 billion, in one of the most massive financial crimes in the history of the world.

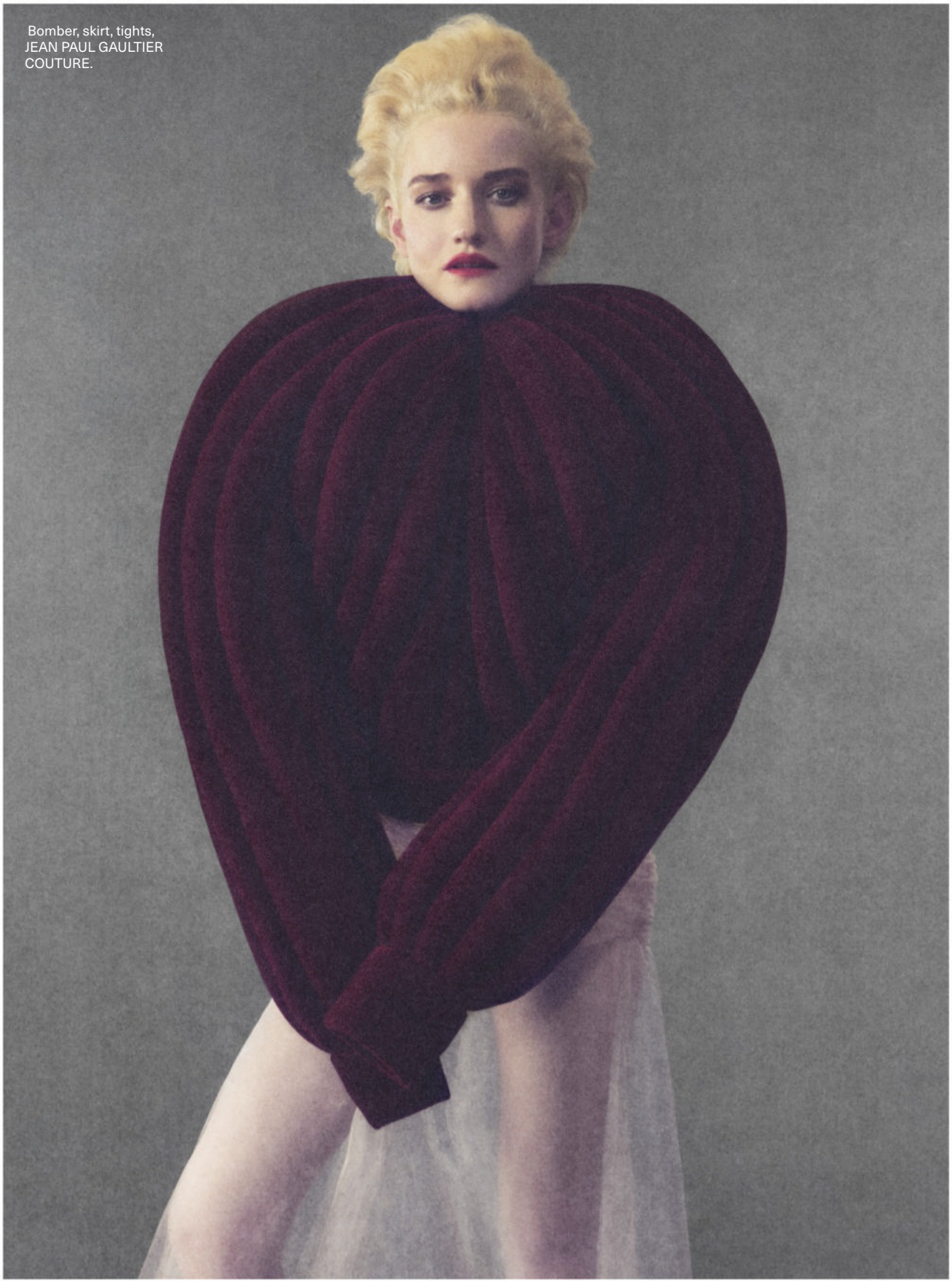
"It was the hardest job I've ever done," Garner says. Known for disappearing into her characters, she says, "I wanted to see how far I could go. I want people to watch this and not see me at all. Like, at all." Another actress might have glammed Caroline up and sanded her rough edges down. Garner asked for a dull brown wig, thick eyeglasses, false teeth, a prosthetic nose, and thick, brown contact lenses. She adopted a tighter posture; a distinctive gait; a new voice, vocal-fried to a mechanical crisp; and a series of laughs, she says, ranging from "one little hiccupy laugh" to the way she "laughs when she's nervous" to the way she "laughs when she lies."

Her classically trained costar Boyle grew a handlebar mustache and pitched his own full-frontal nude scene for Netflix's *House of Guinness*. Yet he remembers meeting Julia-as-Caroline and realizing, "I had to step up my game. It was astonishing. No one actually recognized her. Not one person! I was just blown away. And she is arguably the most talented person in any room she's in."

Oscar winner Graham Moore, the creator of *The Altruists*, says he told Garner she didn't have to go to such extremes and spend almost three hours in the makeup chair every morning. "She said, 'Oh, I've never gotten to act with prosthetics

Dress, BALENCIAGA COUTURE.

Beauty Tip: Add a flush to the cheeks with SISLEY PARIS Phyto-Blush Twist.



Bomber, skirt, tights,
JEAN PAUL GAULTIER
COUTURE.

Dress, BALENCIAGA
COUTURE.

Coat, DOLCE & GABBANA ALTA MODA. Heels, MATIÈRES FÉCALES FOR CHRISTIAN LOUBOUTIN.

Suit, hat, CHANEL COUTURE.

"I don't need to look perfect. I think if there is somewhat of a mess onscreen, what is your instinct to do with a mess? *Your instinct is to reach out and touch it and fix it.*"

before. I really want to learn how.' " Moore calls her a high diver. "Given an array of options, she will choose to jump from the highest board into the deepest water. It's not just that she loves creative challenges, it's that the only creative choices she loves are challenges."

Perhaps the most daring part of playing Caroline was finding a way to allow audiences to connect with a woman who pilfered billions. Jinny Howe, the head of scripted series at Netflix, had bet big on Garner to do almost exactly this before, and hit the jackpot twice, as Garner made a hillbilly criminal and a New York con artist into TV icons. "She portrays what I would classify in quotes as 'unlikable' women with such a ferocity and humanity, where you are just like...I'm with you. She helps us understand who they are in a way that makes it impossible to feel black-and-white about them."

Against all odds, you begin to care about Garner's awkward, selfish Caroline, as you realize her brilliant brain is forever racing ahead of her slow, dumb heart. You feel for her when her erotic Harry Potter fan fic obsession is exposed ("A ride on Draco's Nimbus!"), and when she dresses up in an Indiana Jones costume to seduce a not-into-it Sam. You may even empathize when their financial scam begins to unravel.

Of course, going all in is risky. There's a long list of actors who have become memes or punch lines for going to such extremes (fake noses, prosthetics, obscure accents) and not pulling it off. Garner is aware of the downside risk that comes with trying so hard—painfully so. "Every job I'm on, there always comes a point in the middle of shooting where I feel like I'm messing up," she says, scowling at her Diet Coke. "Like, I'm the worst actor. I feel like I stopped being good a few years ago. It's like that on every job. So now I'm doing this radical acceptance, like, 'Okay, the next job I'll do, I'm probably gonna feel like that, and that's okay....' "

In another effort to combat that fear, and feeling paralyzed by overthinking, she flew to France during the 2023 SAG-AFTRA strike and enrolled at Philippe Gaulier's legendary clown school, which alumnus Sacha Baron Cohen had told her about. Clowning around helped her get more comfortable with embarrassing herself. "Failure is the friend of the clown," she says. "Because ultimately, if you're open to fail, you're more likely to have some sort of a success."

Sipping on her soda and staring out the sunny LA window, Garner says she believes the greatest risk is to take no risks and blend in just like everyone else. "Early in my career, on one of my first trips to LA, they were obsessing about my hair and my teeth. I had to fight with them for, like, two years not to get veneers," she says. "Fashion people were like, 'No, you've got to keep your gap tooth!' There's this Western beauty standard that says everybody should have the same looks." Now, she says, "everyone's got the same teeth"—and no bite.

Garner, who loves the role-play and fantasy of fashion, has had the last laugh. She's the first global brand ambassador for Loewe under its new creative directors, Jack McCollough and Lazaro Hernandez, designers who share her devotion to craft and sense of off-kilter beauty. And when she thinks about those early clashes with agents, she often thinks of pop idol David Bowie. "Once Bowie got new teeth, the edge was gone," Garner says, flashing her own crooked, gap-toothed smile. "That should say everything. As soon as he changed his teeth? He lost the edge."

GARNER ADMITS HER APPROACH IS SO INTENSE she often finds she has more in common with athletes than other actors. She recalls bumping into NBA player Draymond Green at the World Cup final, where they bonded over the way maniacal preparation leaves you free to play and react in the moment—and also how, to both of them, it's so obvious when someone, unlike you, just didn't do the work. "Draymond said he could watch an athlete on the court and know just from their body language when they tap out," Garner says. "And I can tell when people phone it in. For me, if I'm gonna do it half-ass, I'd rather just not do it."

Garner also realizes that some stars are in it for the celebrity. Though she's a fashion week regular, she's discerning about which industry parties she attends, and side-eyes those who aren't. "There are actors who aren't even selective about what events they go to. I'm like, 'How are you working and going to these events? I'm exhausted!' Like, 'Good on you, but I couldn't do that.' " In a "celebrity-obsessed" culture, Garner says, "I want people to hire my acting, not me."

Later, I ask her more about acting and she closes her eyes, as if she's trying to make sure she's not performing her answer but choosing her words carefully.

"I'm not interested in acting," she says. "If I'm portraying that person, that's not an act. It's not my dialogue. But those are my emotions. Those are my feelings." She adds, "I don't need people to like my characters that I play. I need people to be willing to understand where my characters are coming from. I'm in the business of emotions and feelings and how I can make people feel less alone. That's my job."

She opens her striking blue eyes. "Even if they don't like my character—like, they can hate me—my goal in every performance is for somebody to get some kind of physical reaction. Whether it's you're moving forward in your chair, whether you're getting uncomfortable. Maybe you're blushing. Maybe you're doing a grossed-out face. The shitty things are actually going to be the most endearing things, in a weird way. I don't need to look perfect. I think if there is somewhat of a mess onscreen, what is your instinct to do with a mess? Your instinct is to reach out and touch it and fix it." CONTINUED ON PAGE 107

HAIR BY DAVID HARBOROW AT MA+ GROUP; MAKEUP BY JENNA KUCHERA; MANICURE BY JOANNA MEMMI; SET DESIGN BY CHLOE BARRIERE; PRODUCED BY TOWN PRODUCTIONS.

Dress, shoes, DIOR COUTURE.

Jacket, RABANNE. Shirt,
JUNK FOOD CLOTHING.
Pants, GUCCI.

Emotional

On the verge of a world tour and releasing new music, Sombr is bigger than ever. *His feelings are, too.*

Story by SAMUEL MAUDE
Photographed by STEVEN KLEIN
Styled by PAUL SINCLAIRE

Rescue

Coat, boots, SAINT LAURENT BY ANTHONY VACCARELLO. Shirt, JUNK FOOD CLOTHING.

Grooming Tip: For supple, moisturized skin, try LANCÔME Absolue Longevity MD Anticipate The Cream.

SOMBR HATES THE WORD *FAMOUS*. "It's just fucking lame," he exclaims, his arms flailing in the air. "It's self-centered to call yourself famous. I don't even think of it as a positive thing. How can I describe being in the spotlight when I don't always want to be seen?"

Two days after our interview, though, Sombr is very much in the spotlight, playing to a sold-out Lollapalooza crowd. He enters as any rock star would—chauffeured in a spinning-out, light blue 1967 Chevrolet Impala. Clad in bug-eye sunglasses and a black boa, the singer emerges from the car smoking a cigarette and sipping a fruity drink. He has a cocky swagger, one that wasn't present two days earlier when we talked. Stomping to the microphone, he discards the feathered accessory around his guitarist's neck. "I'm more myself and more Zen when I'm on the stage," he says. "I just feel out of place in the regular world and in public."

It would make sense if Sombr, born Shane Michael Boose, was feeling disoriented, as he has had a vertiginous rise to fame. Just a few years ago, he was a student at Fiorello H. LaGuardia High School of Music & Art and Performing Arts in New York training to sing Italian-German arias, and today he can't go out in public without being recorded or swarmed. His songs "Back to Friends" and "Undressed" from his debut album, *I Barely Know Her*, have joined the Billions Club on Spotify; he can go viral on TikTok simply by making a pina colada; and he's about to embark on a massive world tour, even headlining the hallowed Madison Square Garden in his hometown for two consecutive nights. "I'm spending all of the money I'm making on this tour," he says with a smile. "It's going to be fucking incredible, and I'm working so hard to make it the best show possible."

When we meet at a studio in Los Angeles, Sombr's eyes are streaked from a performance at Red Rocks Amphitheatre the night before. Instead of the feathers and sheer Valentino you typically see from him on a red carpet, he's unassuming in a thrifted blue T-shirt, jeans, and beat-up black boots. His energy is also lower than the persona you see onstage. He gives the stressed-out air of the average 21-year-old with a college art history paper to finish and a future to plan, except in his case, Sombr has unfinished music, criticism from online strangers, and the golden cage of fame rattling around in his brain.

The songs he's recently released, "Homewrecker," "Potential," and "My Body Isn't Ready," are performing well, but they're only a glimpse of the very full sonic universe he's creating with his new material. "It's definitely a wider range of sounds," he says. "I don't really see it as experimenting. I don't care how a song ends up, whatever is best for the song. I'm down to make it really weird." Entertainer Quenlin Blackwell, who starred in Sombr's "Homewrecker" music video, says this openness is what sets him apart. "He doesn't look at anything that he does within his career as something that he painstakingly has to do," she says. "There are so many people who are in the entertainment industry whose work gets redundant after a while. I feel like he is so happy, ready, and willing to explore and create."

When Sombr plays me a few tracks during our time together, he watches me take them in and asks me questions after each one. He makes sure that I tell him my favorite and is also quick to let me know they're not quite finished or need to be mixed again. To me, they sound ready for streaming. While I'm sworn to secrecy about the specific contents of his new music, it does seem likely he'll avoid the sophomore slump many artists fall into. The work is exceptional, taking the classic Sombr sound to the next level with introspective lyrics, surprising instruments, and, perhaps, some of the best tracks in his catalog.

"I'm more myself and more Zen when I'm on the stage. *I just feel out of place in the regular world and in public.*"

Sombr, like many singer-songwriters, draws from his own life. His new project is laced with reflections on fame, new relationships, and criticism he's received, all against disco beats, alternative guitars, and head-banging vocals. Each track feels like a journal entry, tracing the moments since he first inked his record deal with Warner Records at 16. "My first album was the first real body of work I put together," Sombr says. "This is kind of the reaction to everything that has happened in the past year. You hear it with some of the songs about the way my life has changed and certain new experiences. All of this stuff has really happened since *I Barely Know Her*."

Whenever we talk about the new material, Sombr lights up. Yes, our conversation traverses areas outside of it, but music seems to be his sanctuary. Born in New York City to Andy Boose and Bennah Serfaty, Sombr grew up listening to rock, pop, and alternative. His father was a musician himself before becoming an events producer working with HIV/AIDS organizations, and his mother also works in HIV/AIDS prevention. Oftentimes, songwriting took the place of schoolwork. "I was failing in school, and we would get emails home pretty much three times a week," Sombr says. "My mom was saying I was spending too much time doing music, because I was flunking and skipping class. You can't expect your kid to be a pop star." But when he self-released his song "Caroline" on TikTok in 2022, his inbox was flooded with record labels hoping to sign the young singer. He dropped out of school and signed with Warner Records, he says, because they were the "hungriest" for him.

This social media Cinderella story earned Sombr the label of "industry plant"—the idea being that his father's celebrity network had somehow boosted him behind the scenes. It's an accusation he is happy to speak to. "Every time I see an artist blow up, I'm like, 'Okay, this artist is great. I love them so much. They're so talented.' Three months later, somehow they're a nepo baby," he says. "I will forever respect my dad

Coat, top, EGONLAB.

Top, pants, GUCCI.
Jacket, RABANNE.
Sautoir, PIAGET.

Coat, top, pants,
EGONLAB.

Coat, DIOR. Pants, GUCCI.

Coat, JEAN PAUL GAULTIER.
Shirt, VALENTINO.

and my mom. I'm so fucking proud of them, because to devote your life to something like that is so incredible and important. To think that that could help me get signed or become a big artist because my dad devotes his life to fight AIDS is just incredibly insane." And once you're signed, Sombr points out, no one's parent can make an artist's music pop—it has to connect with listeners. He learned this lesson firsthand: Post "Caroline," Sombr put out a string of tracks that got little to no play. At one point, he even thought he might get dropped from his record label.

> "When I listened to the 'Dear John' lyrics, it really struck me: 'Don't you think I was *too young to be messed with?*' "

Then, around Christmas in 2024, after smoking a cigarette on his balcony, he sat at the piano with a new tactic. Sombr plunked out a few bass notes, wrote "Back to Friends," and released it. Since it was wedged in those last few mostly-work-free days of December, he didn't expect for the song to take off. "No one was still really paying attention, honestly, because why should they have been?" he says with a chuckle. "Then it came out, and it was my biggest debut on Spotify yet."

As the song continued to rise, so did his star power: bigger venues, an appearance on *The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon*, and collaborations with Blackwell (who mentions a "Homewrecker" video group chat), Addison Rae, and Inde Navarrette (who calls Sombr "a wonderful friend and a great person to have in this industry"). There was even a close encounter with Paul McCartney at an event. ("In the 50 years I've known Paul, he's never come up to a young artist and said it was his honor to meet them," one director told Sombr after he witnessed the interaction.) In November 2025, he nabbed a Grammy nomination for Best New Artist.

Another cosign came from Taylor Swift, who has called him "the future." ("Just waking up to hearing she name-dropped me on the radio, I was like, 'Huh, is this AI?' " he says.) Earlier this year, she hand-selected Sombr to honor her at the Songwriters Hall of Fame ceremony, where he performed "Cardigan" and "Dear John," two of his favorite Swift tracks. " 'Dear John' is a song that she wrote all by herself when she was around the age that I was when I got signed and started doing that," Sombr says. "When I listened to the lyrics, it really struck me: 'Don't you think I was too young to be messed with?' I just think of where she was at that time and where I was at that time, and I'm like, yeah, that's real."

His rapid rise has brought scrutiny and narrowed his social circle to mostly his team and peers. When not on the road, he spends most days at home. The silver barricades between the rock star and his fans don't only exist during a performance.

Whatever his qualms about fame—the word and the experience—Sombr is quick to find the positive. "I love it so much," he begins, "but it's a mindfuck to have the highs and lows—the fact that I was onstage in front of 10,000 people last night and then I woke up in my bedroom in LA....I don't really go out in public anymore, because I have anxiety attacks with people coming up to me. I just get so scared that I didn't perform well or act well for them." He says mentors have told him to focus on the art and shut out the noise. "One of the best pieces of advice the legend has given me—"

"Taylor, right?" I ask.

"The person I look up to most has given me. The amazing pop star. Is that if these hate comments go away, maybe you're not at your peak anymore. I think it's a privilege to be receiving these and rise above it. Ever since she gave me that advice, it's really changed my perspective and has helped."

A moment of particular hate came last year, after a video criticizing him for inappropriate behavior in front of young fans at one of his early shows went viral. Sombr then responded on TikTok, saying that he's "never uttered a serious word in his life," among other defenses. "I wouldn't respond now," he says. "I think responding only makes it worse. I was a teenager when I was kind of just pushed into the spotlight. All of a sudden, this is one of my first instances of being hated on a larger scale. I thought I needed to defend myself.

"I want people of all ages, sexualities, and races, everyone at my show," he continues. "I'm an awkward kid. I don't know what to do in weird moments. That video kind of woke me up. I was like, 'Wait, yeah, that is weird. That is gross.' If you still choose to look at me in a type of way because of that, so be it, but just know that that doesn't represent me as a human. I plan to never say or do something that would even make someone uncomfortable again."

Sombr has also seen the many posts about his body. He towers over me, well above six feet, and he is thin. Earlier this year, the online swirl prompted him to finish and release the song "My Body Isn't Ready," which he had started around the time he wrote "Undressed." The track details his difficulties with his own body image, both as a way to address criticism, but also to serve as an anthem for those who struggle with similar issues. "Women get the worst of it. So who am I to complain? But no, it's real. People fucking body-shame me," he says. "They make fun of how skinny I am, which is why I'm in the fucking gym now. I feel like it's so important to have this message for the kid who's growing up and going through this. Everything you see on the internet is these sexy people with perfect bodies. I want there to be a song for the kid who is growing up and doesn't always love the way he looks, and I want him to know that Sombr feels the same thing."

The musician has always embraced the magnitude of his emotions, from high school to now. Yes, his stage name is created from his initials, Shane Michael Boose, but it also came from all of those big feels, many of which are more intense than ever. "It was just like teenage angst and rejection, being a pothead, skipping class, being pissed off at the world," he says. "Recently, more than ever, I've fallen into a deep, deep depression when I'm on my own. Just being completely honest, I've seen darker points than I've ever seen. I've definitely had some of my darkest thoughts about my life, and I've hit a point lately where I can't see a future. I can only see the past and present," Sombr says. "It's what I signed up for. I'm never going to be an artist who complains about that, because if I wanted to disappear from the spotlight, I would. I'm just somber, man."

HAIR BY WARD AT BRYANT ARTISTS; MAKEUP BY DICK PAGE AT MA+ GROUP; MANICURE BY HONEY FOR P.SHINE; PRODUCED BY TRAVIS KIEWEL AT THATONEPRODUCTION.

Coat, JEAN PAUL GAULTIER. Shirt, VALENTINO.

The visual language of Nicolas Ghesquière's cruise 2027 collection for Louis Vuitton was *color and chaos*, from Belle Epoque florals to *Keith Haring's vibrant Pop Art*.

Photographed by ANDY HARRINGTON
Styled by ALEX WHITE

American Graffiti

Dress, jumpsuit, hat, bag,
LOUIS VUITTON.

Opposite, on model, top: Dress, boots, LOUIS VUITTON.
Bottom: Top, dress, boots, LOUIS VUITTON.

This page: Dress, blouse,
LOUIS VUITTON.

Bodysuit, skirt,
sunglasses,
choker, boots,
LOUIS VUITTON.

This page: Jacket, shorts, bag, LOUIS VUITTON.

Opposite, on model, top: Top, dress, jumpsuit, bag, LOUIS VUITTON. *Center*: Top, skirt, bag, boots, LOUIS VUITTON. *Bottom*: Tops, skirt, choker, boots, LOUIS VUITTON.

HAIR BY EROL KARADAG AND MAKEUP BY FULVIA FAROLFI, BOTH AT MA+ GROUP; MANICURE BY YUKO TSUCHIHASHI AT SUSAN PRICE NYC; CASTING BY ASHLEY BROKAW; MODELS: ANNEMARY ADERIBIGBE AT MARILYN AGENCY, MARY CHUIKOVA AND SONG AH WOO AT THE LIONS, AND MARYLORE HECK AT ELITE; PRODUCED BY FAMILY PROJECTS.

"The Rainbow Supreme necklace uses 68 tourmalines, an October birthstone, in an extraordinary range of colors, anchored by a heritage gourmette chain."

—VINCENZO CASTALDO, CREATIVE DIRECTOR, POMELLATO

OCTOBER

Attention: Cuffing season is postponed until November 13, on order of the stars. *Two retrogrades disrupt our affairs until then:* romantic Venus (October 3–November 13) and communication planet Mercury (October 24–November 13). *Bravely confront whatever surfaces.*

LIBRA
SEPT 23–OCT 22

Budget alert! You're at risk of losing track of your spending this October. No matter how tempting those pre-holiday sales are, high retrograde season could bring buyer's remorse. Delayed gratification is never fun, but your credit score will thank you.

SCORPIO
OCT 23–NOV 21

What did you do to deserve this, Scorpio? Nothing, but the stars are stacked in a challenging way, with both retrogrades passing through your sign. Try to edit your life, from your style to your public-facing presence to your priorities.

SAGITTARIUS
NOV 22–DEC 21

Tap out for the month, Sag. You deserve some cocoon time, tending to your well-being and tying up loose ends instead of starting something new. Cancel lukewarm plans. A mini-sabbatical is your best retrograde coping plan now.

CAPRICORN
DEC 22–JAN 19

The company you keep has a strong influence on your mood this month. Do you feel uplifted or drained by your crew? Take a break from people who deplete you. Reconnecting with an old friend could bring comfort and surprising synergy.

AQUARIUS
JAN 20–FEB 18

Work could be a source of friction this month, as the retrogrades disrupt your professional sector. Be careful, and don't rock the boat in the office. An old colleague or client could resurface with an interesting opportunity. Research before you accept.

PISCES
FEB 19–MAR 20

Patience, Pisces! The urge to escape might be strong, but your flights of fancy could quickly get grounded. Instead of taking big risks now, do your homework to prepare. Watch those edgy and sarcastic comments; they could burn a few bridges.

ARIES
MAR 21–APR 19

The ties that bind could start to feel constricting this month, but don't be too quick to cut them. Venus and Mercury prompt you to have the difficult conversations before doing anything extreme. Everything is a negotiation.

TAURUS
APR 20–MAY 20

Did you write someone off too quickly, Taurus? It might be worth having a second look, but start slowly. Keep one eye open for the same old red flags, but give them a fair chance. People do change!

GEMINI
MAY 21–JUNE 21

If life has gotten chaotic or you're feeling scattered, October's retrogrades let you realign. Streamline, declutter, and return to your healthy routines. An old flame could notice your new radiance.

CANCER
JUNE 22–JULY 22

Lingering love drama could be taking up way too much mental space. Who are you obsessing over and why? Maybe it's not the person, but a few of their redeeming qualities that you like. Identify and then find those elsewhere.

LEO
JULY 23–AUG 22

Your home life could be turbulent under October's retrogrades. But is it revealing things you've been ignoring? Finishing a renovation or setting holiday plans will help you end the year with ease.

VIRGO
AUG 23–SEPT 22

Words can be weapons, especially during October's double retrograde. Whether it's clickbait or rage bait, you're easily hooked—so be mindful. A well-crafted retort might help blow off steam, but the fallout isn't worth it.

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COURTESY OF THE DESIGNER.

IA: I think that we human beings need stories. Stories define us. We can narrate our life with brilliant colors or very dark colors, but nations have their own narratives they create about themselves. For example, the United States has a narrative about the land of the free, home of the brave, the land where all opportunities are available for everybody, the land of equality...and most of that narrative doesn't quite stick to the truth. In order to change a country or to change a person, you have to change the story that you tell about them.
EL: You've said this to me a couple of times: When you write something, it's really about memory. You can't change what happened, but you can decide how you remember it.
IA: Everything is a story. Everything needs a story. So I think that my job as a storyteller is easy, because everybody has a story. There are stories in the air. People say, "Why have you been writing so often and so much about displaced people, migrants, and refugees?" And I say, "Well, because it's in the air." It's the story that, at a sort of unconscious level, we carry as humanity in this moment. As we carry division and hatred and war, it's there. It's a story that is always there, and we can tap into it. And there are many wonderful stories of love and redemption and heroism that are also in the air.

Have you ever thought of writing a novel?
EL: No. Oh my God.
IA: But if you can direct a movie, why not a novel?
EL: I'm sure it's in my brain. I just don't know how to get it out.
IA: Do you think that book is fiction or a memoir?
EL: Oh, definitely fiction. I do not ever want to write a memoir.
IA: Why?
EL: I'm like, "People do not need to know what is really going on behind the scenes." But I do....When people go, "Eva, you do everything. Is there anything you can't do?" I go, "Write. I can't write." And I say that, and a writer once told me, "You have to stop saying you can't write."
IA: Stop saying it!
EL: It's so funny that you say this, because I've always wanted to document my mom and her family. My mom has nine sisters and brothers, and she and my aunts would always tell me all these stories of them growing up....Maybe there's a novel there, because I just want to document their stories. That's all I want to do—to remember them. There's a novel in me. I know there is, one day.
IA: Why don't you start recording and interviewing those ladies who are still alive? I didn't have that resource when I wrote *The House of the Spirits*, but I remembered what my grandfather had told me. They were his stories.
EL: Well, I want to do that with my mom. My mom's 83. But she lies a lot [in her stories]. [*Laughs*]
IA: That's good. That means that she's a storyteller.
EL: She's an unreliable narrator. I'm like, "Mom, that's not what you said happened."
IA: It doesn't matter. That's great, because you have many angles to the story. The process in the brain of remembering and imagining is very similar. So that's why we can never be sure if we remember the real story or if we, in time, have changed it or made it up. When we imagine something, we imagine it because it has roots in memory. It comes from very far back, from a memory. So let your mom lie—and record the lies.
EL: I'm going to record my mom. I'm going to do it. Isabel, *te quiero mucho*.
IA: *Cuídate. Besos.*

Howe compares Garner to Meryl Streep or Daniel Day-Lewis. Moore reaches for Philip Seymour Hoffman: "He never did the same performance twice, and was totally transformative."

Another icon who's influenced Garner is Madonna, the patron saint of reinvention, who approved Garner to play her in her much-anticipated biopic. It's no wonder why—Garner doesn't just have a young Madonna's cropped blonde hair, she has a similar New York intensity. Every now and then, however, there's fresh news that the film is dead. In fact, there's been so much backstage gossip that it proved irresistible to Seth Rogen's Hollywood satire *The Studio*, which built a storyline out of its fictional company, Continental, trying to get the biopic made. So Garner hasn't played Madonna yet, but this year, she did get to spend a few weeks in Venice, playing a fictional version of herself along with Madonna. So how was it?

"It was beyond! I always say it's fine with the Italian queen!" Garner says, beaming. "It was incredible. I've never had an experience like that. Food's terrible, by the way. I had some of the worst Italian food in my life. But Venice is incredible." Garner, who's delighted to be on casual texting terms with Madonna, says, "She's one of the funniest people I've ever met. Like actually. And people don't know that."

She also says the rumors of the Madonna biopic's death have been greatly exaggerated. "I think the movie has to get made," she says with a wry smile. "But we'll see...."

If the film does happen, one thing is certain: She won't play Madge safe. Garner will choose fun hell every time. "I just want to keep taking risks. I think that's what's going to resonate with people with my performances. That I gave everything, you know?"

Garner smiles, then paraphrases Caroline: "You've got to go all in. Always all in."

ELLE (ISSN 0888-0808) (Volume XLII, Number 2) (October 2026) is published monthly, with the exception of combined issues in June/July/Aug and Dec/Jan, by Hearst, 300 West 57th Street, New York, NY 10019 USA. Steven R. Swartz, President and Chief Executive Officer; William R. Hearst III, Chairman; Frank A. Bennack, Jr., Executive Vice Chairman. Hearst Magazine Media, Inc.: Debi Chirichella, President; Regina Buckley, Chief Financial and Strategy Officer and Treasurer; Catherine A. Bostron, Secretary. © 2026 by Hearst Magazine Media, Inc. All rights reserved. ELLE® is used under license from the trademark owner, Hachette Filipacchi Presse. Periodicals postage paid at New York, NY, and additional mailing offices. Canada Post International Publications mail product (Canadian distribution) sales agreement No. 40012499. Editorial and Advertising Offices: 300 West 57th Street, New York, NY 10019. Subscription prices: United States and possessions: $15 for one year. Canada: $48 for one year. Other international locations: $87 for one year. Subscription services: ELLE will, upon receipt of a complete subscription order, undertake fulfillment of that order so as to provide the first copy for delivery by the Postal Service or alternate carrier within four to six weeks. For customer service, changes of address, and subscription orders, log on to service.elle.com or write to Customer Service Dept., ELLE, P.O. Box 5173, Boone, IA 50950. From time to time, we make our subscriber list available to companies that sell goods and services by mail that we believe would interest our readers. If you would rather not receive such offers via postal mail, please send your current mailing label or an exact copy to ELLE, Mail Preference Service, P.O. Box 5173, Boone, IA 50950. You can also visit preferences.hearstmags.com to manage your preferences and opt out of receiving marketing offers by email. To assure quicker service, enclose your mailing label when writing to us or renewing your subscription. Renewal orders must be received at least eight weeks prior to expiration to assure continued service. Manuscripts, drawings, and other material submitted must be accompanied by a stamped, self-addressed envelope. ELLE cannot be responsible for unsolicited material. Printed in USA. Canadian registration number 126018209RT0001. POSTMASTER: Send all UAA to CFS. (See DMM 507.1.5.2); NONPOSTAL AND MILITARY FACILITIES: Send address corrections to ELLE, P.O. Box 5173, Boone, IA 50950.

Seth Cohen Forever

ADAM BRODY

He's back for another season as America's hottest rabbi on *Nobody Wants This*—which, let's be honest, everybody wants.
By Ryan D'Agostino

ELLE: Your Zoom name says "Leighton Meester."
ADAM BRODY: Yes, please call me Leighton Meester.

ELLE: First things first: Noah's wardrobe on *Nobody Wants This* is consistently awesome. Who in your real life is more concerned with how you dress—you or your wife, the aforementioned Leighton Meester?
AB: [*Long pause*] Probably me. I think we both have a nice balance of being fashion conscious and appreciative of art and aesthetics, but it's certainly not all-consuming.

ELLE: Noah and his girlfriend, Joanne (Kristen Bell), are at a point when the marriage question is very real. You've been a married man for 12 years. What wisdom have you picked up?
AB: That there's a duality in all of us. Oftentimes, I feel mature and responsible, and other times, I feel like a little boy still, and I can't believe I'm the age I am. But I think what I've learned is, if you want it to last and you're taking it seriously, there's a certain level of humbling yourself that is required. You have to be willing to adjust. Not change the core of who you are, but really factor someone else's wants and desires and needs into the equation. You're not always going to be right, and you have to accept that. It's a lot easier to always be right when you're single.

"There's a certain level of humbling yourself [in marriage]...it's a lot easier to always be right when you're single."

ELLE: What is the most surprising thing about Kristen?
AB: Just how much pure energy she has and what a sustained presence she is. I think she keeps everyone's mood up. It was just so self-evident that she's a person who has a halo effect. I remember thinking, "Oh wow, she is a real ray of sunshine."

ELLE: Did you have a first job, like a random high school job, before all this?
AB: From ages 14 to 20, I probably had 20 jobs. My first one, when I was 14, was basically as a janitor. I was too young, physically too small. That was stupid. I worked at Noah's Bagels; I was a waiter; I worked at a car wash; at a couple of surf shops; at Robinsons-May Company. I was a valet; I worked at a hotel stocking minibars. Oh, and I worked at a pizza place. I liked jobs where I could talk to people more than the ones that were pure labor.

ELLE: What's something you're not good at that you wish you were great at?
AB: Other languages. Spanish. I'm such a procrastinator. I could do it in a year of Duolingo! But I just don't do it. And that is, to me, a criminal oversight.

ELLE: When and where was your first kiss?
AB: I genuinely don't remember. I do remember where I lost my virginity, which I won't get into.

ELLE: What makes you feel nostalgic?
AB: I get nostalgic for getting coffee and reading the movie reviews in the free *LA Weekly*. Looking at the showtimes and seeing what movie I'm gonna go see that day. I also get nostalgic for combing the aisles of video stores. I worked at Blockbuster and got unlimited rentals. I had roommates and I'd come home with, like, 12 movies. We have everything at our fingertips now, but at the time, that was quite the bounty.

ELLE: Anything else you miss?
AB: I guess I'm also nostalgic for America, pre the current hellscape. I think better days are ahead.

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